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LOCATION MAP

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*IMAGE USED FOR REPRESENTATION PURPOSE ONLY

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Casagrand Premier Builder Limited is proposing, subject to receipt of requisite approvals, market conditions and other considerations, to make an initial public offer of its equity shares and has filed a draft red herring prospectus ("DRHP") with the Securities and Exchange Board of India ("SEBI"). The DRHP is available on the website of our Company, at www.casagrand.co.in, the SEBI at www.sebi.gov.in as well as on the websites of the book running lead managers Motilal Oswal Investment Advisors Limited and DAM Capital Advisors Limited at www.motilaloswalgroup.com and www.damcapital.in respectively, and the websites of the stock exchange(s) at www.nseindia.com and www.bseindia.com, respectively. Any potential investor should note that investment in equity shares involves a high degree of risk and for details relating to such risk, see "Risk Factors" of the RHP, when available. Potential investors should not rely on the DRHP filed with SEBI for making any investment decision.

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MANIPUR VIOLENCE
NIA likely to probe killing of 2 children

NEWS » PAGE 12

PARLEY
Have elections in India become plutocratic?
The role of money in polls under scrutiny

OPINION » PAGE 11



END OF AN ERA
Former Test cricketer Gopinath passes away

SPORT » PAGE 17

Record turnout in Puducherry, Assam; Kerala near all-time high

Incumbents exude confidence after increased voter turnout | Turnout reflects strong resolve to re-elect my govt.: Puducherry CM | ‘Crucial’ polls will provide a bigger mandate in Kerala: Pinarayi Vijayan

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

There was record poll participation in the Assembly elections on Thursday, with the highest-ever voter turnout of 85.91% in Assam and 89.87% in Puducherry, crossing the previous highs of 84.67% for the State in 2016, and 86.19% for the Union Territory in 2011.

Kerala also saw a high voter turnout of 78.27%, with data still coming in and poll officials saying the final figure could even cross the record of 80.54% registered in 1987.

There were 300 Assembly constituencies at stake in Thursday's polling, including 296 seats in Assam, Kerala, and Puducherry with a total electorate of over 5.31 crore who

Making it count

Puducherry, Assam and Kerala marked higher turnouts than in previous polls; this comes against the backdrop of the SIR (special revision in Assam) leading to deletion of names from voter rolls



Voting trip: Puducherry CM N. Rangasamy arrives at a polling booth on a motorbike to cast his vote on Thursday. R. RAGU

Puducherry (30 seats)	
Voter turnout	89.87%
2021 turnout	83.28%
Kerala (140 seats)	
Voter turnout	78.27%
2021 turnout	74.06%
Assam (126 seats)	
Voter turnout	85.91%
2021 turnout	82.04%

PROVISIONAL TURNOUT AS OF FRIDAY 12:30 A.M.

have all been vetted through the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls and the special revision in Assam.

Bypolls were also held to four seats in Karnataka, Nagaland, and Tripura. Counting of votes for all

seats will take place on May 4. The bypolls held in Karnataka's Bagalkot and Davanagere-South saw a voter turnout of 68.67% and 68.43% respectively. In Nagaland's Koridang seat, 82.21% of the electorate cast their ballot, while

80.04% of electors voted in Tripura's Dharmanagar constituency.

Confident sides

Describing the election as crucial for Kerala's future, Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan expressed confi-

dence of victory by a bigger margin for the Communist Party of India (Marxist)-led alliance.

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, seeking a third straight term for the BJP-led NDA, hailed the "historic" turnout, as voter participation crossed 95% in many polling booths.

In Puducherry, where polling remained peaceful barring minor incidents, Chief Minister N. Rangasamy said the high voter turnout reflected a strong resolve to re-elect his government, while the Congress president of the U.T., V. Vaithilingam, said the turnout was because of a strong mood for change.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 12
RELATED REPORTS ON
» PAGES 8, 9 & 13

NEARBY



My schemes will endure beyond my lifetime: Stalin

CHENNAI
Chief Minister M. K. Stalin has asserted that while death is inevitable for all, the welfare schemes implemented by his government would endure beyond his lifetime. » PAGE 8

Sri Lankan Navy arrests 10 fishers for 'poaching'

RAMESWARAM
In a fresh incident, 10 fishermen from Pamban and Thangachimadam in Ramanathapuram district were arrested by the Sri Lankan Navy on charges of poaching on Wednesday night. » PAGE 8

FRIDAYREVIEW » 4 PAGES

'India's FY 27 growth outlook cut to 6.6%

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The World Bank has revised downwards India's growth outlook for 2026-27 to 6.6% from 7.2%, citing the impact of the war in West Asia on household and government consumption, as well as on industrial activity.

The India Development Update report by the World Bank said that "in the absence of the conflict", India's GDP growth was projected at 7.2%, a reflection of better-than-expected growth in 2025-26, "strong initial momentum" in the fourth quarter of that year and a "broad pro-growth reform agenda". "Growth is now projected

Revised figures

India's GDP growth would have been 7.2% in absence of the war, says the report

OUTLOOK FOR FY27:	
Real GDP growth:	6.6% vs 7.6% in FY26
Inflation (Consumer Price Index):	4.9% vs 2.3% in FY26
Net FDI, inflow (as % of GDP):	0.6 vs 0.5 in FY26

at 6.6% in FY27, reflecting headwinds from the Middle East conflict – assuming an extended disruption in global energy (oil and gas) supply till end-2026," the report said.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 12

Over 4,600 in fray for T.N. Assembly polls

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Battle lines for the April 23 Tamil Nadu Assembly election have now been clearly drawn, with the deadline for withdrawal of nominations ending on Thursday, and over 4,600 candidates in the fray.

Besides the DMK-led Secular Progressive Alliance, the AIADMK-led National Democratic Alliance, and Seeman's Naam Tamilar Katchi, actor-politician C. Joseph Vijay's fledgling Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) is also seeking the people's mandate this Assembly election.

As of 11.30 p.m. on Thursday, of the 7,599 nominations received, 4,621 were accepted, 2,460 rejected, and 518 withdrawn.

Even as officials were still finalising these figures, 644 nominations were categorised as 'contesting', as of 11.30 p.m. Karur has the highest number of contestants in a single constituency, with 85 candidates in the race. There were 47 candidates in Perambur, including Mr. Vijay.

The election to the 17th Tamil Nadu Legislative Assembly will see the DMK attempting to retain power and the AIADMK seeking to return to power. The NTK and TVK are hoping to be elected to power.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 8

Iran ceasefire teeters over disputes on Lebanon, Hormuz ahead of Pak. talks

Associated Press
Agence France-Presse
DUBAI/ISLAMABAD

The tentative ceasefire in the Iran war staggered on Thursday under the weight of Israel's intense bombardment of Lebanon, Tehran's continued chokehold on the Strait of Hormuz, and uncertainty over whether negotiators can find common ground on a range of other differences.

Hours after the ceasefire was announced on Wednesday, Israel pounded Beirut with air strikes, resulting in the deadliest day in the country since the war began on February 28.

Lebanon's Health Ministry said on Thursday that the latest Israeli strikes killed more than 300 people and wounded at least 1,150 across the country.

Israel's strikes "signal deception and non-compliance" and render negotiations "meaningless", Iran's President Masoud Pezeshkian said. "Our hands remain on the trigger," he added.



A family picture among the rubble of a building hit by Israeli strikes the day before in central Beirut, Lebanon, on Thursday. AP

Iran's Parliament Speaker Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf said Lebanon was a key part of the two-week ceasefire. "Lebanon and the entire Resistance Axis as Iran's allies, form an inseparable part of the ceasefire," Mr. Ghalibaf said in a post on X, adding that

"ceasefire violations carry explicit costs and STRONG responses".

Iran and the U.S. – which both declared victory in the wake of the ceasefire announcement – appeared to try to pressure each other on Thursday even as both countries were due to meet in Pakistan for talks this weekend.

Semiofficial news agencies in Iran suggested forces have mined the Strait of Hormuz while U.S. President Donald Trump warned that Iran would be hit even harder than before if it did not fulfil the agreement.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 12
'NUCLEAR CONCERN'
» PAGE 16



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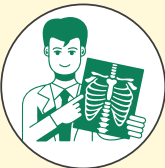


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Section of Perungudi residents to boycott Assembly election

They say the DMK and the AIADMK failed to address a long-pending land patta issue even after several appeals to the MLAs; 600 voters in the locality have decided to skip the upcoming polls

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A section of residents in Perungudi has planned to boycott the upcoming Assembly election due to the failure of the two main political parties, the DMK and the AIADMK, to resolve the land issue in their locality for more than five decades.

The residents have put up display boards about the proposed boycott of the Assembly election. Perungudi comes under the Sholinganallur Assembly constituency.

Created in 1984, Kamarajar Nagar in Perungudi is one of the oldest residential layouts, with more than 200 plots. Now, it has developed into a promi-



The residents have put up display boards in their locality about the proposed boycott of the Assembly election.

nent residential locality situated along the Information Technology corridor.

The residents say they have not been issued computerised pattas despite the availability of manual pattas. They are aggrieved that even after making sev-

Officials had refused to grant pattas to Kamarajar Nagar residents, claiming that the plots come under the Land Ceiling Act

eral appeals to the MLAs of both the political parties over the years, no steps have been taken to resolve the issue.

Officials have refused to grant them pattas claiming that the plots come under the Land Ceiling Act.

M. Michael Aruldas, president of the Kamarajar Nagar Residents' Welfare Association, said 600 voters in the locality had decided to boycott the polls. The residents had pur-

chased vacant plots through a housing society called Kanniyakumari Nadar Association and obtained all approvals, including manual pattas, and constructed houses.

P. Sajeewan, a long-time resident of the locality, said though the Supreme Court in a 2016 judgment upheld the Madras High Court order against the State government order to designate these plots under the Land Ceiling Act, the officials of the Revenue Department had not issued the computerised pattas to the residents.

As the Revenue Department has upgraded the system from manual pattas, computerised pattas have become mandatory for the sale of property.

Vyasarpadi man dies after assault during funeral procession

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A 29-year-old man died following an assault during a quarrel at a funeral procession in Washermenpet on Wednesday.

The deceased, Imran, of MKB Nagar in Vyasarpadi, worked as a drummer at funeral ceremonies. He was listed as a 'C' category rowdy with five pending cases, according to police records.

The police said Imran consumed alcohol while playing the drums at a relative's funeral at the Moolakothalam burial ground. An argument broke out when he bought tea for the fellow drummers, including Kader Basha of Sathayamurthy Nagar.

The verbal altercation soon turned violent, with Kader Basha allegedly as-

saulting Imran and striking him on the chest. Imran later complained of severe chest pain and returned home by autorickshaw.

His condition deteriorated shortly after reaching home, following which his family rushed him to the Government Stanley Hospital. However, doctors declared him brought dead.

Preliminary medical findings indicated internal chest injuries and minor external injuries.

Based on a complaint lodged by his wife, Durga, the Washermenpet police registered a case and arrested Kader Basha and another individual who was present at the scene.

The police said the exact cause of death would be confirmed after the post-mortem examination. Further investigation is in progress.



Chennai Weather	max	min
Tiruvallur	35	27
Chennai Airport	34	29
Chennai City	32	29

Timings

CHENNAI		
FRIDAY, APR. 10		
RISE	06:00	SET 18:21
RISE	00:33	SET 12:04
SATURDAY, APR. 11		
RISE	05:59	SET 18:21
RISE	01:20	SET 12:57
SUNDAY, APR. 12		
RISE	05:59	SET 18:21
RISE	02:04	SET 13:49

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8.5 kg of ganja worth ₹4.27 lakh seized at Perambur, Chengalpattu

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Railway Protection Force (RPF) seized a total of 8.5 kg of contraband ganja and tobacco products, worth ₹4.27 lakh, in two separate operations across the Chennai Division on Thursday.

These are part of the in-

tensified surveillance ahead of the upcoming election.

In the first case, an RPF team conducted a search on Tatanagar-Ernakulam Express at Perambur Railway Station.

During the inspection, officials found an abandoned travel bag containing four bundles of dry

ganja, weighing 7.5 kg and worth ₹3.75 lakh.

At Chengalpattu Railway Station, the RPF personnel inspected Kacheguda-Puducherry Express.

The search led to the recovery of unclaimed bag, which contained 1 kg of dry ganja worth ₹50,000 as well as gutkha valued at ₹2,000.



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Naada Inbam, 24992672 Today 6.15pm Dr.Srividiya RS Iyer and Dr.Sudha RS Iyer, M Vijay, Sherthalai Ananthakrishnan. Concert supported by Smt Lokanayaki Srinivasan. Ragas-udha Hall.

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Today's young people are growing up in a world where certainty is rare, knowledge has a short shelf-life, and every system; from education to careers to technology — is being rewritten in real time. Instead of following fixed paths, they are learning to live in beta: a state of continuous testing, refraining, failing, updating, and trying again.

The Beta Generation invites young people to see life not as a finished product but as an evolving prototype, to embrace uncertainty as creative fuel rather than existential threat. This generation is learning that becoming is more powerful than being, that starting imperfectly beats waiting for readiness, and that the ability to iterate may be the most valuable skill of all.

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Candidates fan out across city as campaign gathers pace

Udhayanidhi Stalin lists key projects carried out in Ponneri while seeking votes for Congress nominee Durai Chandrasekar; he urges Saidapet residents to support DMK leader Ma. Subramanian; AIADMK's Alandur candidate Saravanan assures people that property tax will be reduced if his party returns to power; TVK's Thousand Lights contestant Prabhakar confident of people's support

FIELD POSITION

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Stepping up the DMK's election campaign in Chennai for the second consecutive day, Deputy Chief Minister Udhayanidhi Stalin on Thursday canvassed for votes in various parts of the city, foregrounding the DMK-led government's welfare record and development projects in the respective constituencies. Starting his campaign in Ponneri constituency, Ti-

ruvallur district, in support of Congress candidate and sitting MLA Durai Chandrasekar, Mr. Udhayanidhi said the DMK government had reached out to the people through its achievements. "We are coming to you to seek votes because of our achievements," he told the crowd in his trademark conversational style. Listing key projects carried out in the constituency, including for Pazhaverkadu, he urged the voters to elect Mr. Chandrasekar for the second time by a margin of 25,000 votes this time.



Election fever: Deputy Chief Minister Udhayanidhi Stalin canvassing votes for Congress nominee Durai Chandrasekar in the Ponneri constituency on Thursday. PTI

Later in Saidapet, he highlighted various infrastructure development works carried out by Health Minister Ma. Subra-

manian, who is contesting again from the constituency. He cited the ₹450-crore Kalaigiar Centenary Super Speciality Hospital and the

₹151-crore 200-bed National Centre of Ageing, and the upcoming Guindy Race Course eco-park. "These are only a sample of our

achievements," said Mr. Udhayanidhi. Responding to criticism from AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswamy, he defended the DMK's role during the COVID-19 pandemic, asserting that party cadre, MLAs, and the Chief Minister himself were among the first to be on the ground assisting people. In Alandur constituency, AIADMK candidate S. Saravanan, who is contesting against the incumbent DMK MLA, T.M. Anbarasan, canvassed for votes in an open vehicle and visited several narrow streets. The

van had a digital board displaying AIADMK's poll promises. Highlighting the increasing electricity charges and property tax, he assured voters that property tax would be reduced once the AIADMK returns to power. **Enthusiastic welcome** CPI(M) candidate L. Sundararaj, contesting from the Tiruvottiur constituency as part of the Secular Progressive Alliance, received an enthusiastic welcome during his campaign in wards 11 and 12, including Sathangadu High Road and Vasantha Nagar.

He asked for voters' support to continue development works in the locality. Door-to-door campaign was the strategy adopted by Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam candidate for Thousand Lights J.C.D. Prabhakar who campaigned at Choolaimedu. He went door to door seeking votes in Sankarapuram, Sherfuddin Street, Ameer John Street, and Abdulla Street. Though the DMK dominated the Assembly segment, he said he is confident of winning the constituency because of people's support for party president C. Joseph Vijay.

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

DEATH


Mrs. JANANI KRISHNASWAMY
Attained Paramapadam on Mar 23, 2026 in London.
Ever loved and missed by Karthik, Dr. Parthasarathy, Geetha, Akshay, Aarthi, Agastya, Kasthuri, members of the Thirumalai & Alwar families, Care Team and Friends.

DEATH

In memory of

Dr. K Ramamurthi
Bharathi Kaavalur
Brakes India Limited (Retd)
passed away peacefully in his sleep on 07-04-2026
His family and friends fondly cherish a life well-lived. His thoughts, words, and gestures have touched many over the years.

DEATH

IN LOVING REMEMBRANCE
VIJAYA RAJAN
(Retired Chairperson, Crafts Council of India)

Smt. Vijaya Rajan, wife of Sri. V.S. Rajan, passed away on 9th April 2026.
Instrumental in establishing Craft Council of India, in Chennai in 1976, a founding chairperson of CCI, her commitment to craft was extraordinary. She was also the President of the World Craft Council (Asia Pacific) for 4 years.
Cremation at Besant Nagar crematorium at 10:30am on 10th April
Deeply grieved by her son Muraarie Rajan and family.
Contact: 9003020269

DEATH

IN LOVING MEMORY
"I have fought the good fight, I have finished the race, I have kept the faith." - 2 Timothy 4:7

DR. J.D. JOHN SAMUEL
(1944 - 2026)
Former Joint Commissioner, Civil Supplies & Consumer Protection, Tamil Nadu Government
Funeral Service
Saturday, 11th April, 11:30 AM
St. George's Cathedral Church, Cathedral Road, Chennai (Near American Embassy)
Followed by burial at the same place
Deeply mourned by:
Wife: Dr. (Mrs.) Manorama Samuel
Daughter & Son-in-law: Dr. Jayanthi Peter & Dr. J.V. Peter
Son & Daughter-in-law: Joshua Madan & Susan Joshua
Grandchildren: Dr. Joel, Dr. Josline, Dr. Jenita, (Dr.) Joanna & Judah
Great-grandchildren: David & Caleb

BIRTHDAY REMEMBRANCE

BIRTHDAY REMEMBRANCE
"Today happens to be the Birth Anniversary of one of the greatest Coonoorians,
Dr. A.M. SELVARAJ,
Professor of Medicine, Madras Medical College, fondly called as AMS, he was revered by his Pupils, Juniors and Peers alike for his encyclopaedic knowledge in Medicine, his dedication in treating patients, his incredible work ethics and of course his eccentricities".
Facebook April 10th 2019.

10-04-1930
Prof. (Dr.) ALANDUR MEGHANATHAN SELVARAJ
10th April 1930 – 23rd September 2011 – A Tribute
Dr. ARCOT LAKSHMANSWAMY
MEGHANATHAN MUDALIAR EDUCATIONAL TRUST
SRI LAKSHMI DEVI CHARITABLE TRUST
DR. ALANDUR MEGHANATHAN SELVARAJ MEDICAL TRUST
Anna Nagar, Chennai.
Ph: 044 - 43557496 Cell : 9790826928

THE IDEA IS TO DIE YOUNG AS LATE AS POSSIBLE

CD GOPINATH
1930 - 2026
With profound sadness we announce the passing of CD Gopinath, peacefully at home in Chennai on 9th April 2026.
Beloved to us all he is deeply mourned. He held life lightly with trust and enjoyment. He gave us the confidence to stand tall and held us all safe. With love and gratitude, we will miss his presence. May his onward journey be as fulfilling as this one has been.
He leaves behind
His wife, Comala Gopinath,
Children, grands and great grands.
Kamini Sundaram Arvind Gopinath Ranjith Gopinath
Aryama Sundaram Chitra Gopinath Chelvi Gopinath
Skanda Siddharth Shivani
Nivruti Nanda
Madhulika Pratika
Devi
Shivam
Nieces & nephews, extended family and friends
Everyone at INS past and present.
The cortege will leave from
2 Karpagam Gardens, First Cross St., Adyar, Chennai at 1:30 pm
on 10th April 2026 to the Besant Nagar crematorium.
Contact no: 98409 32925 / 98418 05120

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

18th DEATH ANNIVERSARY

ANTHONY SILVEIRA
DGM (Retd) - IOB
06.02.1928 - 10.04.2008
"Your cherished memories will always remain in our hearts guiding and blessing us."
Remembered by:
GEETA P SHETTI
GM (Retd), Indian Overseas Bank
Flat H/103, Satt Adhars
Basilio Complex, St. Inez, Panaji, Goa - 403001
Mobile : 07715043211

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

Nineth Anniversary

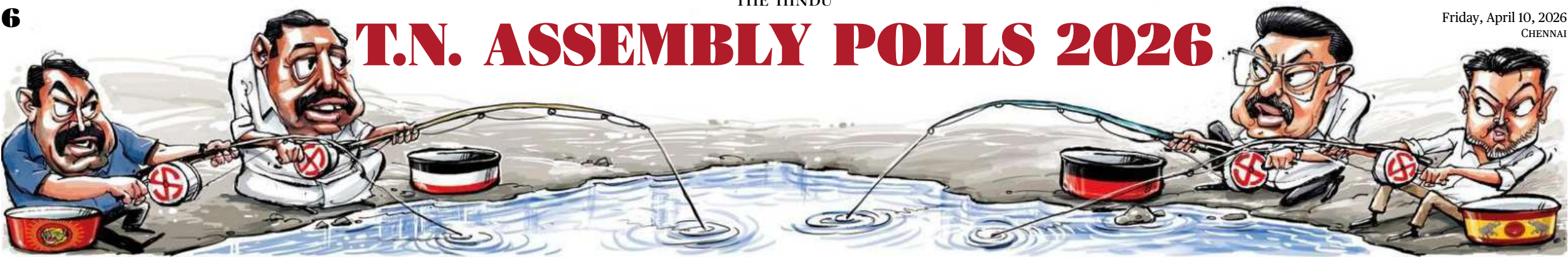
In fond memory of
V SOUNDARARAJAN
(10-04-1935 - 10-04-2017)
Rtd.Sr.Audit Officer, AG Kerala
Wife: Rajalakshmi,
Sons: Srinivasaraghavan, Kannan,
Daughter: Radhika,
Son-in-Law: Balaji Srinivasan,
Daughters-in-law: Anurada, Amirtha
Grand Children: Dr. Siraag, Dr. Srijiith,
Dr. Mahima Srinidhi, Swetha, Ct: +91 9791183328

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

FIRST YEAR ANNIVERSARY

RM.ALAMELU ACHI
W/o Late Sri.V.S.A.RM.AN.Ramasamy Chettiar, Kottaiyur
D.O.B:10.02.1937 D.O.D: 10.04.2025
Shyamala Pictures, Chennai.
"We love you and will miss your presence forever"
Fondly remembered by
Sons, Daughters in law & Grandchildren





Farm gate prices remain a key issue in both the Cauvery delta and in non-delta regions.R. VENAGESH

Clamour for better prices persists in T.N.'s agriculture belt

S. Ganesan
TIRUCHI

Almost two decades since the National Commission on Farmers, headed by renowned agricultural scientist M.S. Swaminathan, recommended providing 50% profit for farm produce to make farming viable, farmers' incomes remain a debatable issue.

The issue crops up every election season, with political parties promising better procurement prices by increasing the incentive given by the State, over and above the minimum support price (MSP) fixed by the Centre, mainly for paddy and sugarcane.

Though farmers' organisations are divided on various issues this election, with quite a few of them taking a political stand openly – some against the DMK government in the State, and others against the BJP government at the Centre – most of them agree that farm gate prices remain the primary concern of the average farmer, both in the Cauvery delta and in non-delta regions.

"Agriculture is increasingly non-remunerative and not a rewarding profession. The price factor is one of the main issues here," observes Arupathy P. Kalyanam, general secretary of the Federation of Farmers' Associations in the Cauvery Delta Districts.

The M.S. Swaminathan Commission had recommended a formula for calculating the minimum support price – C2 + 50% (50% more than the weighted average cost of production, classified as C2 by the Commission for Agricultural Costs and Prices). "The Commission gave its recommendations in 2006; we are yet to reap the benefits," rues P. Ayyakannu, president, Desiya Thennindiya Nadigal Innaiippu Vivasayigal Sangam.

As far as paddy is concerned, both the DMK and the AIADMK have promised to provide ₹3,500 a quintal. "This would work out close to the formula recommended by the Swaminathan Commission. Both the parties have announced ₹4,500 per tonne of sugar cane. But implementation is the key here – the DMK implemented its previous election promise [of providing ₹2,500 a quintal] after four years. Farmers expect the price to be offered soon after a new regime takes over," Mr. Kalyanam says.

Taking a critical view of the DMK government's policies, P.R. Pandian, president, Coordination Committee of All Farmers' Associations of Tamil Nadu, contends that even the ₹2,500 for paddy came about due to the annual increase of about ₹100 in the MSP by the Centre. "The DMK promised to procure and fix the price of horticulture crops by forming district-level committees; they have not fulfilled this and several other promises," he says.

The Tamil Nadu Vivasaya Sangankalin Kootamaippu, a federation of a group of associations led by Cauvery Dhanapalan, too has demanded legal protection for the prices of 23 varieties of farm produce, including paddy, sugar cane, copra and milk.

Crash in prices

In recent months, farmers in rain-fed areas in Perambalur and Tiruchi were hit hard by the crash in the price of maize to well below the MSP fixed by the Commission for Agricultural Costs and Prices (CACP).

"There is no mechanism to enforce the MSP in the absence of government procurement. While the CACP's MSP for maize was ₹2,400 a quintal for the 2025-26 kharif season, traders were offering less than ₹1,800," says R. Raja Chidambaram, State Secretary, Tamizhaga Vivasayigal Sangam.

However, a veteran farmers' leader from Karur, Mahadhanapuram V. Rajaram, feels that reducing the crises in the agriculture sector to the price factor alone would be a "simplistic approach".

"We should move towards making agriculture an industry through mechanisation and value-addition. The sector should be able to provide white-collar jobs to attract educated youth," he says.

From mass conferences to digital platforms: the DMK's 77-year journey

Largely dependent on the charisma and eloquence of its founder Annadurai, the DMK also had an array of articulate leaders, backed by an enviable organisational structure. It reflected the aspirations and sentiments of Tamil Nadu, where passion for language often overrides other considerations

B. Kolappan
CHENNAI

Kooli kettan, athan gundadi pattu sethan – My husband asked for wages, but died in a police firing – was a popular slogan of the DMK that had captured the imagination of the people. The late poet Kudiyarasu, who was with the DMK before switching to Vaiko's MDMK, often recalled how the slogan, coined by DMK veteran M. Karunanidhi, transformed the dynamics of the 1967 Assembly election.

The DMK won the election, consigning the ruling Congress to the margins of Tamil Nadu politics. But the DMK's march to power was far from an overnight exercise. Founded in 1949, the party had to wait 18 years to taste power. Subsequently, after being unseated by M.G. Ramachandran (MGR), it was pushed back into the Opposition for 13 years.

Largely dependent on the charisma and eloquence of its founder, C.N. Annadurai, the DMK also had an array of articulate leaders, backed by an enviable organisational structure. The party and its leadership reflected the aspirations and sentiments of Tamil Nadu, where passion for language often overrides other considerations. They spoke in a lan-

guage the Congress couldn't match.

Karunanidhi's rise

After Anna's demise, Karunanidhi, hailed as *Kalaigarnar* by his followers, proved to be an ideal successor, in leadership and articulation.

The university-educated leadership of the DMK paled in comparison to his political acumen and shrewdness. Election after election, he led the party with resilience, maintaining equanimity in the face of defeat while keeping firm control over the organisation. If splits and the emergence of new political parties did not knock the DMK off its axis, much of the credit goes to Karunanidhi.

The DMK's journey from an era of massive conferences and public meetings to the digital world of voter outreach is remarkable. The party now combines a penitentiary IT wing with leaders capable of organising large conferences, though these are now confined to a day.

The days of massive conferences are captured by R. Kannan in his book, *Anna: The Life and Times of C.N. Annadurai*. "The alliance's strength was on show at the DMK's four-day Virugambakkam (Madras) conference, which began on 29 December, 1966. It would take six hours for



Two of a kind: After Annadurai's demise, Karunanidhi, hailed as *Kalaigarnar* by his followers, proved to be an ideal successor. The picture shows the two leaders at an event in 1961. THE HINDU ARCHIVES

the conference procession to pass through."

MGR's presence at the conference galvanised the crowd. Annadurai famously remarked: "Just by showing his face all over Tamil Nadu, I can get several lakh votes."

Even in 1996, the conference in Tirunelveli witnessed similar crowds, reinforcing its appeal, with people waiting for hours to listen to Karunanidhi.

The era of MGR

The DMK government, for all its far-reaching measures – including land reforms, nationalisation of transport, and renaming of the Madras Presidency as

Tamil Nadu – quickly fell prey to the systemic problem of corruption. Annadurai was deeply pained, but could not discipline his colleagues, writes Mr. Kannan, recalling former Minister Panruti S. Ramachandran. After Anna's death in 1969, Karunanidhi assumed the leadership of the party with the support of MGR. However, he paid a heavy price for expelling MGR from the party in 1972.

The DMK could not recapture power in MGR's lifetime. In 1984, addressing voters through All India Radio, Karunanidhi said, "*Ungal kaal cheruppaaga theinthu kadamaiyaatra*

AIADMK's poll promise of crop loan waiver raises questions of feasibility

T. Ramakrishnan
CHENNAI

The AIADMK's electoral promise of a waiver of loans taken through cooperative institutions has raised the question of feasibility in the wake of the Reserve Bank of India's (RBI) directions.

The AIADMK's scheme covers crop loans obtained by farmers from primary agricultural credit cooperative societies (PACCS) and loans obtained by persons with disabilities and pavement vendors from cooperative banks. Though the ruling DMK is silent this time on the issue of waiver of crop loans, it made an assurance five years ago in this regard.

RBI guidelines

In December 2024 and November 2025, the RBI issued two separate sets of guidelines on the subject of the resolution of stressed assets of different banks, including cooperative banks. The November 2025 communication specifically pertains to rural cooperative banks.

Broadly, the RBI favours upfront detailed budgetary provision/funding towards any proposed Debt Relief Schemes (DRS) to fully cover the required settlement amount. Where lenders have dues from the government, pertaining to earlier DRS schemes, new schemes should be announced only on a fully pre-funded basis.

This approach varies from the practice adopted

Aiding agriculture

An account of crop loans disbursed through various institutions, including cooperative societies, in Tamil Nadu

Year	Crop loans from cooperative societies (₹ in crore)	Farmers benefited	Total crop loans from various institutions (₹ in crore)
2021-22	10,292	14.84 lakh	1,49,293
2022-23	13,119	17.05 lakh	2,11,568
2023-24	15,543	18.36 lakh	2,79,408
2024-25	15,692	17.37 lakh	N.A.
2025-26	19,000	18 lakh	N.A.

Source: Policy notes of the Cooperation Department of the Tamil Nadu government and the State Focus Paper (2025-26) of the National Bank for Agriculture and Rural Development | N.A.: not available



In December 2024 and November 2025, the RBI issued guidelines for the resolution of stressed assets of various banks, including cooperative banks

by the Tamil Nadu government in the past 20 years, wherein the coverage of crop loan waiver amounts was spread over five years.

For instance, the State government, five years ago, waived the crop loans of farmers to the tune of ₹12,111 crore – the outstanding figure as on January 31, 2021. In the first year (2021-22), it released ₹4,250 crore payable to the National Bank for Agricul-

ture and Rural Development (NABARD) and ₹554 crore towards interest on the waived amount payable to the cooperative societies.

In the event of the AIADMK capturing power and deciding to implement its proposal, it may be noted that the RBI's stipulations require the State government to make a provision for the entire amount in the first year itself. This may compound the fiscal situation of the State government, which is already providing a number of welfare schemes and freebies.

The RBI's rationale against the idea of a loan waiver is that if such schemes are announced without due consideration

kaathirukkiirom" (We are ready to serve like the slip-pers on your feet). Yet, despite MGR's illness at the time, he proved invincible.

The DMK returned to Fort St. George only after his death, aided by a multi-cornered contest involving V.N. Janaki and the other by Jayalalithaa, and the Congress. However, the government was short-lived, as the Centre dismissed it.

The 1991 Assembly polls, held following the assassination of former Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi, decimated the DMK, which won just two seats. However, the excesses of the Jayalalithaa government helped the DMK return to power, forging an alliance with G.K. Moopannar's Tamil Maanila Congress, and with film star Rajinikanth's support.

In 1999, after Jayalalithaa pulled down the Vajpayee government at the Centre, the DMK quickly embraced the BJP and won the Lok Sabha polls. It then allied with the Congress, winning back-to-back elections at the Centre and returning to power in the State. It was during this period that it became entangled in the 2G spectrum allegations.

Comeback under Stalin

Between 2011 and 2021, the DMK was out of power. In-

cumbent Chief Minister M.K. Stalin brought the party back to power in 2021.

There is an argument that the DMK has never won two consecutive elections since 1977. The emergence of actor C. Joseph Vijay's Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam as a potential disruptor in this election is posing a challenge.

Has the DMK, once the natural home of youth, begun to lose that connection? The party's Rajya Sabha member, Constantine Ravindran, disagrees. "Mr. Vijay has only the youth as his followers. On the other hand, the DMK has a support base across all sections of society. It is a myth that all youngsters are behind him," he contends. Content matters in elections, he says, adding that the DMK's manifesto speaks louder than those of its rivals, and that the party's IT wing has been successful in taking its message to the masses.

Mr. Ravindran says the final three days of any election are crucial. "I have been involved in elections since 1989. Fifty per cent of the voters make their decision only in the last three days. There is a saying in Tamil: *Chinnavan vithitha vellamai kali pogathu* (a field cultivated by the inexperienced will be full of weeds). The organisational strength of the DMK makes the difference."

Audio-enabled VVPAT system sought for the visually impaired

S. Vijay Kumar
CHENNAI

The lack of assistive devices, such as an audio-enabled Voter Verifiable Paper Audit Trail (VVPAT) system, compels visually impaired voters to rely on others to cast their vote, thereby compromising the secrecy of the ballot, says a representation sent by an NGO to the Election Commission of India (EC).

In its plea to the Chief Electoral Officer of Tamil Nadu, Nethrodaya, an NGO working for the welfare and upliftment of visually impaired persons, has sought the introduction of an audio-enabled VVPAT system for the upcoming Assembly election.

The VVPAT system attached to the Electronic Voting Machine (EVM) provides visual verification of the vote by printing a slip of paper, which the voters are not allowed to take home.

The NGO said persons with visual impairments encountered several challenges while exercising their franchise at polling booths.

"The primary concern is the lack of assistive devices, such as audio-enabled Electronic Voting Machines, which restricts their independent participation. This raises serious concerns regarding privacy and autonomy, as visually impaired voters are often compelled to rely on others to cast their vote,

The lack of assistive devices for visually impaired voters compromises the secrecy of the ballot, says an NGO

thereby compromising the secrecy of the ballot," the NGO said in its representation.

Counsel for the NGO R.S. Raveendhren said the proposed audio-enabled VVPAT system would provide audio confirmation of the selected candidate through headphones after a vote is cast, instead of relying solely on visual verification. The EC, he said, was duty-bound to implement Section 11 of the Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016, to ensure that the polling, the electoral process, and all materials are easily understandable and accessible to persons with disabilities.

"The VVPAT system serves only a class of voters who do not have any disability. Rule 49-N of the Conduct of Elections Rules, 1961, which provides for a companion to assist visually impaired voters, does not provide privacy, autonomy, and secrecy in the right of voting," Mr. Raveendhren said.

Going by the 2011 Census, a report of the Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment says there are 1,27,405 visually impaired persons in Tamil Nadu.

M CH-CHE

INBRIEF



Turnout drops in bypolls at Davangere South, Bagalkot

Polling for the byelections to Davangere South and Bagalkot Assembly constituencies in Karnataka went on smoothly, barring few technical glitches and a stray instance of a minor clash in Davangere. However, both constituencies recorded lower polling percentages compared to the 2023 Assembly election. As per preliminary data, Bagalkot recorded a polling percentage of 68.67% (69.39% in 2023) and Davangere South recorded 68.43% (69.48% in 2023).

Seven held in ticket scam at Dwaraka Tirumala temple

The police in Eluru district, Andhra Pradesh arrested seven persons, including a software engineer, for their alleged involvement in a fake darshan ticket racket at Lord Venkateswara Swamy temple at Dwaraka Tirumala, on Thursday. "The accused were printing and issuing fake darshan tickets, worth ₹200 to devotees. The fraud came to light when tickets were scanned at the entrance of the temple," said Eluru Deputy Superintendent of Police.

Fire breaks out at chemical solvent unit in Hyderabad

Massive fire broke out at a chemical solvent unit in Jeedimetla area of Hyderabad on Thursday morning, destroying industrial material. The blaze erupted at a chemical solvent unit in Ram Reddy Nagar around 7.23 a.m., prompting an extensive firefighting operation. Four fire tenders from Sanathnagar, Secunderabad, Kukatpally and Cantonment were pressed into service to bring the fire under control. The fire was finally doused after more than five hours at around 1 p.m..

Kerala records turnout of 78.27% in high stakes polls

Voter turnout stood at 80.86% among women, 75.01% among men, and 57.04% among transgender voters; the highest since 1987 Assembly elections; polling booths were monitored with AI cameras

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Kerala recorded 78.27% polling in the Assembly elections held on Thursday after what has been a short but intense period of electioneering in the State. According to the Election Commission of India (EC), 80.86% of female voters, 75.01% of male voters, and 57.04% of transgender voters in Kerala cast their votes.

Voters in Kerala must now wait till May 4 for the polled votes to be counted and the results declared in the 140 constituencies. Leaders of all the three fronts – the ruling Communist Party of India (Marxist)-led Left Democratic Front, Congress-led United Democratic Front, and the Bharatiya Janata Party-led National Democratic Alliance – exuded confidence about the outcome.

Thursday's voter turnout was higher than that of the 2021 Assembly elections and the highest since the 1987 Assembly polls (80.54%). But it failed to live up to the expectations of the EC which had set a target of 85%.

Among the districts, Kozhikode had the highest polling percentage at 81.36%, followed by Palakkad 80.56%, according to the latest updates on the EC's ECINET app. The turnout in the remaining 12 districts are Alappuzha



Star attraction: LDF candidate V. Sivankutty and UDF candidate K.S. Sabarinadhan stand alongside actor Mohanlal to exercise their franchise in Thiruvananthapuram. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

77.39%, Ernakulam 79.89%, Idukki 77.15%, Kannur 78.60%, Kasaragod 79.11%, Kollam 76.29%, Kottayam 74.77%, Malappuram 79.82%, Pathanamthitta 70.76%, Thiruvananthapuram 77.04%, Thrissur 77.11%, and Wayanad 78.81%. The polling data is as of 12.30 a.m. on Friday.

There were 883 candidates in the fray for the Assembly elections.

Polling began at 7 a.m. and proceeded at a brisk pace till noon. Shortly after 1 p.m., the polling percentage crossed the halfway mark, prompting Chief Electoral Officer Rathan U. Kelkar to remark that if the pace maintains, the turnout should touch 90%. In the afternoon, the pace slowed down a bit but by 5 p.m. it crossed 75%. Bar-

ring a few incidents, including instances of technical glitches reported in electronic voting machines, the exercise was largely peaceful across the State.

AI monitoring
This time, Election officials tried out a new artificial intelligence (AI)-assisted video management system that issues automatic alerts in case of long queues or crowding at the polling stations. Each station had two cameras each, placed inside and outside the station. Total 60,990 cameras were streaming footage. At the control room, one of the screens is dedicated to pinpointing polling stations with long queues (at least 10 voters waiting) outside them.

Confident of a bigger win for LDF, says Pinarayi

The Hindu Bureau
KANNUR

Kerala Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan on Thursday expressed confidence that the CPI(M)-led Left Democratic Front (LDF) would get a bigger mandate this time.

After casting his vote at a school in Pinarayi in Kannur district, he said Kerala was on a strong path towards becoming a developed State, with achievements across sectors that must continue uninterrupted.

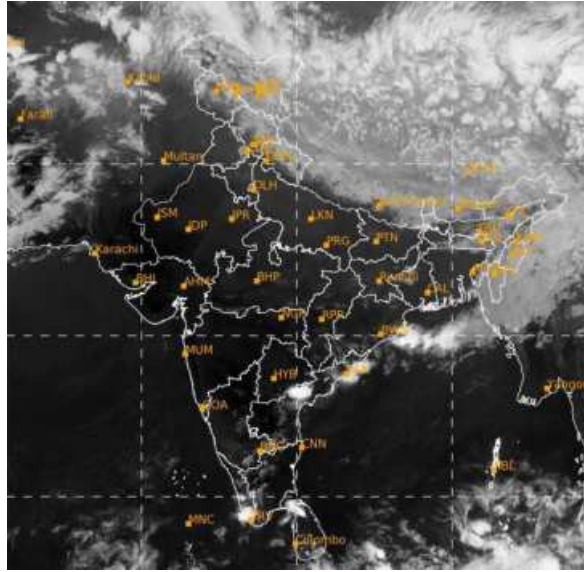
He asserted that people favoured development and believed that only the LDF could ensure governance without deficiencies.

Attempts at vote manipulation through cash inducement, and communal campaigns, would not influence Kerala's electorate, the Chief Minister said.

Kerala's Leader of the Opposition V.D. Satheesan said on Thursday that the United Democratic Front (UDF) would come to power in the State with over 100 seats. "The mood of the electorate is in favour of the UDF this time," he said after casting his vote in North Paravur.

WEATHERWATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select metros yesterday



TEMPERATURE DATA: IMD, POLLUTION DATA: CPCB, MAP: INSAT/IMD (TAKEN AT 18.15 HRS)

Forecast for Friday: Heavy rainfall likely at isolated places over Arunachal Pradesh. Thunderstorm with lightning/gusty winds likely at isolated places over Meghalaya, Tripura, West Bengal, Sikkim, Odisha, Tamil Nadu and Kerala. Hot and humid weather likely at isolated places over Konkan & Goa, Karnataka and Andhra Pradesh

CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN		
Agartala		16.....	26.3.....	19.6	Kozhikode		35.8.....	26.6	
Ahmedabad			35.7.....	23.9	Kurnool		40.7.....	27.7	
Aizawl		5.4.....	25.7.....	18.8	Lucknow		4.5.....	30.5.....	16.0
Allahabad		3.2.....	34.0.....	19.2	Madurai		39.0.....	26.5	
Bengaluru			35.4.....	24.6	Mangaluru		33.8.....	25.0	
Bhopal			34.0.....	16.4	Mumbai		33.5.....	25.2	
Bhubaneswar		11.....	34.7.....	22.8	Mysuru		36.....	20.0	
Chandigarh		2.....	28.0.....	12.3	New Delhi		30.8.....	16.3	
Chennai			37.8.....	28.3	Patna		0.6.....	31.5.....	21.0
Coimbatore			36.4.....	23.4	Port Blair			25.4	
Dehradun		10.....	27.4.....	11.5	Puducherry		32.....	28.3	
Gangtok			11.....	13.9.....	9.3	Pune		35.9.....	22.4
Goa			34.4.....	24.8	Raipur		36.7.....	25.9	
Guwahati		0.4.....	27.4.....	20.6	Ranchi		30.6.....	17.6	
Hubballi			37.0.....	22.0	Shillong		4.....	20.2.....	10.4
Hyderabad			37.8.....	25.8	Shimla		14.....	18.8.....	7.0
Imphal			25.1.....	20.1	Srinagar		6.....	17.1.....	7.0
Jaipur			30.8.....	18.8	Thiruvananthapuram			35.3.....	28.1
Kochi			32.8.....	27.2	Tiruchi			38.9.....	27.6
Kohima			20.5.....	13.0	Vijayawada			37.4.....	27.4
Kolkata		28.....	27.0.....	20.7	Visakhapatnam			34.....	28.0

(Rainfall data in mm; temperature in Celsius)

Pollutants in the air you are breathing

CITIES	SO ₂	NO ₂	CO	PM2.5	PM10	CODE	Yesterday
Ahmedabad		79		81	36		In observation made at 4.00 p.m., Pithampur
Bengaluru		20		30	40		Madhya Pradesh recorded an overall air quality index (AQI) score of 192
Chennai		14		10	22		indicating a moderate level of pollution. In contrast, Pamore, Jammu & Kashmir recorded a healthy AQI score of 14
Delhi		49		45	22		
Hyderabad		27		33	19		
Kolkata			8	54	40		
Lucknow		11		46	31		
Mumbai			76	33		43	
Pune			78	98		74	
Visakhapatnam		36		70	16		

Air Quality Code: ■ Poor ■ Moderate ■ Good (Readings indicate average AQI)
SO₂: Sulphur Dioxide. Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, making breathing difficult. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain culturally important objects such as statues and monuments.
NO₂: Nitrogen Dioxide. Aggravates respiratory illness, causes haze to form by reacting with other air particles, causes acid rain, pollutes coastal waters.
CO: Carbon monoxide. High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness, and even death.
PM2.5 & PM10: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease

TAMIL NADU PUBLIC SERVICE COMMISSION
No.3, TNPSC Road, Chennai - 600 003.

Notification No: 3/2026
Advertisement No: 732
Dated: 09.04.2026

TAMIL NADU PUBLIC SERVICE COMMISSION DEPARTMENTAL EXAMINATIONS, MAY - 2026

The Departmental Examinations, MAY - 2026 are to be held from 22.05.2026 to 26.05.2026 and 30.05.2026 to 02.06.2026. The candidates shall apply only online from 09.04.2026. The last date for submission of online application is 30.04.2026 till 11.59 pm. All the Objective Type Tests (100% & Partial, i.e., 40% / 60% / 80%) will be conducted as Computer Based Test. All the Descriptive Type Tests (100% & Partial, i.e., 20% / 40% / 60%) will be conducted in the existing method of written examination.

Instructions to candidates for Departmental Examinations / Syllabus / Scheme / Pattern/ Name of the Test / Test Code / Fees Structure / Time Table etc., are available in the Commission's website www.tnpsc.gov.in / www.tnpscexams.in

DIPR/329/Display/2026
Secretary & Controller of Examinations

POSTGRADUATE INSTITUTE OF MEDICAL EDUCATION & RESEARCH, CHANDIGARH

XXXIX CONVOCATION

The XXXIX Convocation for conferring academic degrees to candidates in respect of Ph.D, DM, MCh, MD, MS and MDS courses whose terms have been completed till December, 2025 will be held on 27th April, 2026 in the Bhargava Auditorium of PGIMER, Chandigarh. A rehearsal will be held on Sunday, the 26th April, 2026 at 9:00 A.M. in the Bhargava Auditorium. It is compulsory for all recipients of degrees/medals to attend the rehearsal. Those who fail to participate in the rehearsal will not be allowed to take part on the day of Convocation. Kindly intimate the confirmation for participation in the Convocation by 15th April, 2026 through google form link (bit.ly/28gconvocation). The list of awardees & detailed information is available on the website of the Institute. (<http://pgimer.edu.in>)

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Bengal blues

SIR, not governance, dominates political discourse in poll-bound Bengal

West Bengal, one of the largest and politically consequential States in eastern India, goes to polls on April 23, with a second phase on April 29. As attention shifts from other elections held on Thursday, the eastern State presents a dispiriting picture. An election that should be about governance and livelihoods is instead being fought over identity and the composition of the electoral roll itself. The Trinamool Congress has been in power for three terms after wresting power from the Left Front. In a more rational world, the outcome of the 2026 Assembly elections would have depended upon the performance of the Mamata Banerjee-led government over the last 15 years and how it has positioned a State that continues to occupy a middling or low rank in major socio-economic indicators. Yet, governance has almost never been the criterion that has determined voter choices in the State in the recent past, and this election does not seem to be an exception. The State, one of a dozen that underwent a Special Intensive Revision (SIR) process carried out by the Election Commission of India, registered a drop of 91 lakh electors – a 12% decrease. Ground reports revealed that the exercise, unlike in Bihar, where deletions were more evenly distributed on communal lines, disproportionately affected minority electors and those living in the border districts of West Bengal. Apart from those deleted initially in the SIR enumeration process, more than 60 lakh voters were flagged as having “logical discrepancies” in the draft roll. The Supreme Court, which had to intervene to decide the eligibility of these electors, appointed judicial officers for the task. But that process resulted in the disenfranchisement of 27 lakh electors, who have now been given the option of approaching tribunals. There is no clarity on whether this tribunal process will conclude before the election.

The anger on the ground over the SIR and the onerous burdens placed on electors to prove their eligibility, due to largely a flawed enumeration process adopted by an insouciant ECI, has now become an election issue on its own, sidestepping civic and governance issues. The Trinamool has projected the discontents over the SIR as a consequence of the Centre's and the ECI's machinations, while the BJP has wielded the SIR as a tool to polarise elections on religious lines. West Bengal desperately requires a polity where contestation is over how to revive employment-driven industrial growth in a largely agrarian and services economy, not over the religious and linguistic identities of voters.

Timely inaction

Slowing growth and rising inflation necessitated unchanged rates

The RBI Monetary Policy Committee's (MPC) decision to keep interest rates unchanged – a “wait and watch” approach, in the Governor's words – is a sensible move. At a time when hasty words and deeds have roiled world markets, economies, and even households, a measured policy response was the need of the hour. The challenge before the MPC is that the main tool it has – the repo rate – impacts growth and inflation in opposite ways. That is, if it had raised rates to try to contain an anticipated surge in inflation, this would have hurt growth. On the other hand, if it lowered rates to boost growth, this would have pushed inflation up. The war in West Asia has resulted in both of these undesirable outcomes: supply chain constraints have pushed up costs while also dragging down growth. A rate change at this juncture could have made matters significantly worse and further dampened the mood in the economy. In his speech, RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra predicted that India's GDP would grow 6.9% in 2026-27. Given that this is still the first month of the financial year, the forecast is likely to change considerably over the subsequent MPC announcements. For example, the MPC in April last year had predicted that growth in 2025-26 would be 6.5%. In contrast, the government's latest estimate for the year is 7.6%. Considerable uncertainty continues to persist in West Asia, with shipping companies still hesitant to brave the Strait of Hormuz.

All of this, coupled with the fuel constraints, will continue to hamper growth in 2026-27. The RBI lowered its growth forecast for the first quarter by just 0.1 percentage points, which might end up being an over-optimistic reading of the situation. The World Bank's India Development Update report, released on Thursday, predicts a slowdown in industrial growth in India over the course of this financial year. Consumer and government demand, too, is expected to slow as both groups try to tighten their belts. Inflation, on the other hand, is expected to accelerate considerably to 4.6%, according to the RBI. Yet, the MPC was correct not to raise rates since most of the inflationary pressure is due to supply issues rather than demand conditions. Raising rates would not only have slowed growth further, but even the primary objective of containing inflation would not have been met. A lot of factors need to play out before monetary policy can act – the war, the U.S. tariff-related investigations, greater clarity on a potential El Nino impact on the monsoon this year, to name a few. Until then, inaction is the best course of action.

Making scholarships integral to India's academic culture

If India is to take its Gross Enrolment Ratio (GER) in higher education to 50%, the question is not only how many institutions the country can build, but who is actually able to walk through their gates and graduate.

India has been making gradual progress to expand capacity; the number of higher educational institutions has grown from 51,534 (2014-15) to over 70,000 last year, as per the 2025-26 Economic Survey. Yet the national GER stands at 29.5 (2022-23). Such limited participation highlights that seats alone do not create students. Education transforms lives when access, affordability, and academic quality come together. For many young Indians, especially in second-and third-tier towns, the binding constraint is not aspiration; it is the cost and risk of participation. This is why scholarships cannot remain a peripheral add-on to the system. They need to be designed, and tailored as an integral and embedded pathway into higher education.

A pressing need

The country is witnessing three intersecting challenges. There is an access challenge across regions and social groups; an affordability challenge that turns higher education into a long-term investment for families; and a quality challenge that determines whether and to what extent enrolment translates into true learning and occupational pursuit. Enrolment rises when those who qualify can afford to participate, and when institutions are confident that diversity and merit will strengthen, not dilute, academic life.

India knows this well: there is a lot of talent that is widely distributed, but with no opportunity. Increasing enrolments will depend less on convincing already advantaged families and more on releasing the pool of capable students who are currently held back by cost, distance, and uncertainty about the benefits of enrolment. Scholarships sit precisely at this hinge point. They are not only instruments of financial support; they can also mould a student's life, ensuring academic fulfilment as well as overall individual enhancement through provisions beyond material aid, such as leadership development, exposure to a wider world of interests, and career guidance.

The Department of Higher Education supports students through scholarships, interest subsidies on education loans, and credit guarantees. The National Scholarship Portal functions as a common window for State schemes, and hosts information on scholarship programmes across



Pramath Raj Sinha

Founder and Chairperson, Board of Trustees, Ashoka University, Delhi-NCR. Views expressed are personal and do not reflect the views of the University

Scholarships sit at the intersection of equity, quality, and growth. They influence who and how many enter higher education, and who persists

ministries, departments and regulatory bodies. One such programme is the Central Sector Scheme of Scholarship for College and University Students that provides up to 82,000 scholarships each year across undergraduate, postgraduate, and professional courses. Alongside this, corporate foundations, trusts, and non-profits have also created well-known programmes, often focused on merit-cum-means in fields such as engineering and management.

While this is meaningful progress, most scholarships are limited in number, and are still treated as financial plug-ins. The deeper question is whether scholarships can become a pathway which students actively opt into not only for financial reasons, but also for academic community and mentorship.

Lessons from history

India's own history should be the first source of inspiration. In the ancient institution of higher learning, *Takshashila*, students were known to have had as many as five options to pay their education fees: pay up front; work with and learn from the teachers; defer and pay after graduation; receive scholarships from home regions; or rely on support from a charitable community for disadvantaged students. The principle was straightforward – ability should not be turned away for lack of means, and that institutions should find ways to welcome talent.

The opportunity before India is not only to improve scholarships, but to reimagine what a scholarship represents. One can imagine scholarships that are designed as multi-year commitments rather than annual renewals, giving students the confidence to plan their academic lives with a certain stability. Institutional density and enrolment can be studied in order to design region-based scholarships that focus on underserved States and districts. One can also imagine programme-specific pathways that link scholarships to areas of national and regional need. A scholarship attached to a vocational degree in artificial intelligence, advanced manufacturing, or healthcare, anchored in a district with low participation but high demand, could raise enrolment while strengthening skills and employability.

Public policy and regulation can gently encourage this shift. Incentives such as tax benefits for endowments, or matching funds through private philanthropy, can attract long-term capital into scholarships that are designed to grow and sustain.

Nari Shakti, India's defining reform for the next decade

Over the past decade, India has done something few nations have achieved at scale: it has moved women's empowerment from intent to infrastructure. This shift did not happen organically; it was designed. Under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, policy has placed women at the centre of development recognising that when women move forward, entire economies accelerate.

The results are visible and measurable. More than 57 crore bank accounts have been opened under the PM Jan Dhan Yojana, with over 55% held by women, giving millions their first foothold in the formal financial system. Nearly 10 crore women, organised into over 90 lakh self-help groups, are now driving grassroots entrepreneurship and local economic resilience. The Pradhan Mantri Ujjwala Yojana has reached over 10.5 crore households, reducing health risks and freeing women from time-intensive labour. Moreover, access to credit has expanded, with close to 70% of MUDRA loans going to women entrepreneurs. Female labour force participation has also risen to nearly 37%, reversing a long-standing decline.

In healthcare, programmes such as the Ayushman Bharat and the Pradhan Mantri Surakshit Matritva Abhiyan have expanded access and reduced vulnerability at critical life stages. Initiatives like the Beti Bachao Beti Padhao scheme have begun to shift deeply embedded social attitudes.

Individually, these are strong programmes. Taken together, they represent a structural shift in how India views women not as recipients of support, but as drivers of growth. For policymakers and administrators, this offers a clear lesson: scale works when design, delivery, and accountability are aligned.

In healthcare, where the author's expertise lies, outcomes improve when systems are built



Sangita Reddy

Joint Managing Director, Apollo Hospitals

Over the next five years, India must invest in preparing women to lead not just electorally, but institutionally

around real needs, and not theoretical models. Where access is simplified; delivery is consistent; and outcomes are tracked, impact follows. And yet, the next phase will demand even greater focus, as the challenge before us is no longer policy creation, it is policy penetration.

The last mile

Despite the scale of programmes, awareness gaps remain. Enrolment is uneven, and last-mile delivery continues to depend on local capacity. For every woman who has accessed opportunity, there are many more who remain on the margins due to lack of access. This is where administrative leadership becomes decisive.

India must move from announcing schemes to ensuring saturation; from measuring outputs to tracking outcomes; and from eligibility on paper to access in practice. District-level ownership, data-driven monitoring, and convergence across departments will be critical. And while technology can accelerate this, it cannot replace on-ground accountability. Therefore, the question for every policymaker is simple: how do we ensure that no eligible woman is left out?

This is where the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam can become one of the most consequential reforms of our time. By expanding women's representation in legislative bodies, it creates the possibility of aligning policy design with lived experience. Women leaders can bring their insights shaped by community realities which can strengthen programmes, and their delivery, targeting, and adoption.

Additionally, the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam when implemented with intent, can trigger a multiplier effect with more women in leadership, more responsive policy, higher participation, and stronger leadership pipelines, making reform self-reinforcing.

Globally, we are entering a decade defined by

Performance-linked frameworks can recognise and reward institutions that demonstrate outcomes across merit, need, and potential. India already has early examples of what such thinking can look like. Ashoka University evaluates financial aid independently of academic admission, following a need-sensitive process where a student's ability to pay is assessed separately from the admission decision. About 20% students receive free education owing to a 100% scholarship, and roughly half of the students receive some form of financial support, while maintaining strong academic standards. The Indian School of Business (ISB) has built a donor-supported scholarship ecosystem across categories that reflect merit and need, including support for those from the armed forces and those who are returning to the development sector. Every year, the ISB awards between 250 and 280 scholarships across its programmes, and notably, 40% of the founding class of the recently launched PGP-Young Leaders programme is supported by scholarships. In both cases, scholarships are not an afterthought. They are critical to the kind of academic community these institutions are trying to build.

International experience reinforces the point. Whether it be multidisciplinary scholarship programmes at U.S. universities or provincial and city-level scholarships in China aligned to local development priorities, the most effective systems treat scholarships as a core part of their academic cultures.

From the margins to the centre

India still needs to expand and diversify its higher educational system. But expansion alone will not deliver a 50% enrolment ratio that also deepens learning and social mobility. Meaningful absorption can only happen when capable students are supported and inspired to look ahead, regardless of where they come from.

This is not a narrow funding conversation; it is about building an ecosystem. Scholarships sit at the intersection of equity, quality, and growth. They influence who and how many enter higher education, and who persists. They shape the social and intellectual life of campuses and the credibility of institutions. They also contribute to the nation's trajectory, throwing light on how its talent is discovered, understood, and developed.

If the goal is not only more students, but also more mobility and national capability, then scholarships deserve to move from the margins to the centre of our higher education strategy.

knowledge, innovation, and technology. India already has a strong base, with one of the highest proportions of women in STEM education globally. This is an opportune moment to translate this gain into leadership across sectors such as healthcare, science, enterprise, and governance without losing time.

The past decade has shown what is possible when political will aligns with policy design. With today's strong foundation, the implementation of Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam can move empowerment beyond access, to authority.

The way forward

However, representation must translate into capability, and capability must be built through institutional support to ensure that implementation delivers results. Over the next five years, India must invest in preparing women to lead not just electorally, but institutionally. This means structured mentorship, policy exposure, and administrative support systems that enable effective governance.

It also means rethinking how the country designs policy itself. Programmes must be simpler to access and faster to deliver. Feedback loops must be strengthened so that policy evolves with need. And success must be measured not just by coverage, but by change in outcomes across sectors. As India moves towards its vision of becoming a developed nation by 2047, this is not a peripheral agenda – it is central to its success. Women's participation is directly linked to economic growth, social stability, and institutional effectiveness.

If India can achieve saturation in access, strengthen participation, and enable leadership, it will not just empower its women – it will redefine its growth trajectory. For policymakers and administrators, the mandate is clear: the time to implement is now.

partner Kuldeep Yadav has sparked massive outrage. This is a heartbreaking pill to swallow for DC and will haunt Miller for years!

R. Sivakumar
Chennai



To read more letters online, scan the QR code. Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the full postal address and the full name or the name with initials.

Higher oil prices are already pushing fuel costs and inflation in India. Talks in Islamabad may help if both sides settle on clear terms and follow them steadily.

S. Balasubramanian

Tamil Nadu

Last minute defeat

In what will go down as the biggest misjudging moment in the 2026 IPL games so

far, David Miller has become the villain for Delhi Capitals fans overnight. That Miller refused an easy single, off the penultimate delivery of the final over bowled by Gujarat Titan's Prasidh Krishna, has painstakingly cost the match for his team! While Miller's blistering 41 off 19 balls brought DC to the doorstep of victory, his shocking refusal to trust his

Corrections & Clarifications

Mohsina Kidwai was elected to the Uttar Pradesh Legislative Council at the age of 30 and not 28. (News page — “Mohsina Kidwai, a former Union Minister and veteran Congress leader, passes away”, April 9)

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LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Lingering uncertainty

Apropos ‘MPC factors in ceasefire to keep repo rate unchanged’ (April 9), the RBI's cautious, wait-and-watch outlook is on expected lines as India braces for the long-term ramifications of the conflict in West Asia on its economy. Despite India's strong macroeconomic fundamentals, the delayed and inadequate restoration of supply chains is bound to impact both growth and inflation figures. Minimising the unsettling of the broader economy in the face of rising global

uncertainties is the real test.

S.S. Paul

West Bengal

No end in sight

The near collapse of the U.S.-Iran-Israel ceasefire reflects that all three sides operate with very low trust in each other's commitments. The war has shown that Iran is not a weak nation as expected by the U.S. And while now Donald Trump is inclined for a peace deal, Israel wants unrest. Such wars are a plague on the world and damage poor

nations economically.

Kshirasagara Balaji Rao

Hyderabad

Unclear ceasefire

The ceasefire gives some relief, but its scope still feels unclear in practice. Different views on Lebanon continue to weaken trust between the U.S. and Iran. Continued strikes suggest that control on the ground remains limited. This creates doubt about how firmly the agreement is being followed. The Strait of Hormuz stays sensitive, as any tension there quickly affects global oil supply.

Have elections in India become plutocratic?



M.R. Madhavan

Co-founder and president of PRS Legislative Research



R. Rangarajan

Former IAS officer and author of 'Courseware on Polity Simplified'

PARLEY

As Tamil Nadu, Kerala, West Bengal, Assam and Puducherry head to the polls, India's vibrant democracy is on full display once again. But behind the rallies and roadshows, there is a growing concern: elections are becoming increasingly expensive. With political parties spending heavily on campaigns, advertising, and outreach, the role of money in shaping electoral competition is under scrutiny. Data shows that nearly 93% of India's Members of Parliament are croropatris, raising the question of whether access to political power is becoming more unequal. What does this mean for smaller parties and independent candidates? And what would it take to fix it? M.R. Madhavan and R. Rangarajan discuss in a conversation moderated by V. Nivedita. Edited excerpts:

How expensive are elections in India?

M.R. Madhavan: We actually don't know. Officially, the limit for a Lok Sabha candidate is ₹95 lakh. But we know, from talking to anyone who has contested, that they spend far higher than that. There is no official number, but there are estimates, and they vary from State to State. I have heard numbers in the range of ₹50 crore to ₹100 crore being spent in some places by each candidate. But there is no real data because none of this is accounted, audited, or reported.

The Election Commission mandates that candidates can spend only a few lakhs, but the candidates spend higher than that. How is the EC allowing them to do that?

R. Rangarajan: This is a very complicated problem. I have studied it, taught it, and even contested an election, where I spent ₹20 lakh for a parliamentary seat and got a handsome 1.35 lakh votes, about 12% of the constituency. But that is for a candidate who simply wants to participate. For winning, as Madhavan said, the official limit is ₹95 lakh for a parliamentary constituency and ₹40 lakh for an assembly segment. In reality, the expenditure runs into tens of crores. There is no limit on party's expenditure but only on candidate. It has become an uneven playing field. The Election Commission does send observers, but they are there only from the day of nomination to election day. In those 20 days, how much can they monitor? A lot of spending happens in unaccounted cash.

Are smaller parties and independent candidates being pushed out because of high expenditure?



Elections have become increasingly expensive. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCKPHOTO

R.R.: Money is not a sufficient condition to win an election, but it has become a necessary condition. People spend crores and still lose. Unless there is a strong wave in favour of a leader or a movement, which happens rarely, like the AAP's victory in Delhi in 2014. In most elections that are dominated by national and regional parties, well-meaning independents and smaller parties are only going to be also-rans. They cannot compete with the money power of larger parties.

M.R.: This is standard across democracies. Take the U.S., a large country with 50 States, but effectively only two major parties dominate. India has more parties, but if you look at it at the State-level, typically, there are two main contenders, sometimes three, and they eventually form coalitions. This is typical in a first-past-the-post system, where even a 1-2% margin can decide the winner. So parties tend to consolidate. Smaller parties and independents usually don't stay in power, except in rare cases.

Is a cap necessary on election spending by individual candidates?

M.R.: The problem is that we need to spend a lot of money for the size of constituencies we have, for holding rallies, and to reach out to people. Even if you are not giving money to make people vote for you, you would still need a lot money to campaign legitimately. The current limits are too low. One option is to increase the limit. Today, even if someone raises funds transparently, they cannot spend beyond the limit without risking disqualification. So, candidates are forced to use black money.

R.R.: It is a catch-22 situation. Increasing limits may allow candidates to spend more white money, because the bigger parties tend to have resourceful candidates. But I think there is a logic in keeping the limit at this level. In fact,

many people will say even this limit is quite a high number. Because of the first-past-the-post system, candidates leave no stone unturned to win, including cash distribution. State funding of elections has been discussed, but it is not practical to implement. There could be a cap on party funding as well, similar to the U.K. system, where total party spending is linked to the number of candidates. A mixed-member proportional representation system could also help smaller parties gain representation, but that would require major changes.

Will imposing caps on parties' spending on elections level the playing field?

M.R.: Limits can be imposed, but it will drive the spending underground. You'll have more spending with black money, which is not reported. The reported amount stays within the limit. How do you manage that given the way our country works? One option is to remove limits and focus on transparency. That is, let candidates spend money and report it accurately.

R.R.: Even then, the use of black money will continue. There is already no limit on party spending, yet official disclosures are far lower than actual estimates. In the 2024 general election, the BJP said it spent ₹1,500 crore and the Congress said it spent around ₹600 crore in their affidavit to the Election Commission. The official expenditure of all the big national and State parties put together is around ₹3,300-3,400 crore. But the Centre for Media Studies estimates that close to ₹1 lakh crore was spent.

Is a level-playing field even possible?

R.R.: It requires political will. One simple reform could be banning government-funded advertisements six months before elections. Currently, governments can spend on ads until elections are announced, just 35-40 days before the elections. Other reforms include proportional representation.

M.R.: The question is, is money the primary driver of election results? Evidence shows that parties spending heavily still lose if they fail to convince voters. I would also focus on post-election functioning. Other than the fact that they elect the prime minister or chief minister, they become irrelevant because they have to abide by the party whip. That is where we need real reforms.

The Supreme Court scrapped electoral bonds, but the opacity remains.

R.R.: I think the Supreme Court rightly struck it down. And we got to know the details of the donors because they were asked to disclose it. And we got to know who had given how much to which party. I think that was a very ill-conceived scheme.. It would have been completely opaque. Companies Act was amended to say that even loss-making companies can contribute, which is against the interests of shareholders. The electoral bond scheme would have neither brought transparency nor accountability.

How do we build a system that has both accountability and transparency?

M.R.: It's very important to have transparency because that brings in accountability. If you see 'X' has funded this party which won the election and that party takes a decision that benefits 'X', it is at least open and visible. That visibility would bring in accountability. But there's a question – should companies be allowed to fund elections? They don't have a vote. Only citizens vote. So should such an entity be allowed to fund elections at all? We had actually banned it sometime in the late 60s. We allowed it again about 15 years later. Both were done for certain political reasons, but the fundamental question should be discussed.

R.R.: That is a fair point. Democracies the world over are a nexus between big corporate interests and politicians. This would require political will to change the law and that is not forthcoming, unfortunately.

What role do civil society, pressure groups and media play in fixing the system?

R.R.: I think the most important role they play is at least spreading awareness.

M.R.: But it's also important to note that people do know a lot of things and they act in a particular way. In fact, Milan Vaishnav had a very nice book called 'Why Crime Pays', which says that people actively vote for certain politicians who have a criminal background. That in fact benefits them in an election. Beyond awareness, we'll have to address the core reasons why people behave in a certain way so that we actually have a more thriving democracy.



To listen to the full interview
Scan the code or go to the link
www.thehindu.com

NOTEBOOK

Diplomats are the last to leave Indian missions in war zones

They stay on in the face of danger, sending dispatches on the situation, setting up calls with officials, and helping Indian citizens in safe exit

Suhasini Haidar

War is the failure of diplomacy, said British MP and activist Tony Benn. However, in a world where diplomacy is increasingly not being given a chance to succeed, it is important to remember the diplomats who keep working, despite the war raging outside their mission windows. “If there's a horde of people fleeing a burning building, apart from the firefighters, the only people crazy enough to be going in are journalists,” my professor would say. However, few think about the diplomats, based in India's missions around the world who choose to stay inside the ‘burning building’ even as the situation gets more heated. As the world saw the U.S. President's words threatening a “civilization will die” if Iran did not comply with his demands this week, and feared the worst would follow, Indian diplomats based in Tehran and other towns outside the capital were working around the clock inside the embassy, with a basement parking area to run for as a bunker in case of airstrikes. Some were sending dispatches on the situation there, some setting up meetings and calls with officials, some organising stocks of food, water, medicines, and some working on making arrangements for Indian citizens in the country to leave through land boundaries. Similar scenes must be playing out at the Indian missions in Tel Aviv, Beirut, Abu Dhabi, Riyadh and other cities over the past month. Over the course of my career, I have met many such diplomats, stoic in the face of danger, often having to take the call for the entire embassy and families on whether to continue to stay given the risks, and to know when to take the equally difficult decision – to leave. My professor's words flashed through my mind as we entered into Beirut harbour during the 2006 Israeli bombardment of Lebanon, and could see smoke from buildings as well as the airport where Israel Defence Forces' (IDF) jets had struck

the tarmac and aircraft, forcing it to close. I was one of a group of journalists on board the INS Mumbai, who were being dropped there, while the Indian Navy was going to evacuate thousands of Indians as part of Operation Sukoon. As Beirut harbour came into view, our first sight was Indian Embassy personnel, setting up desks right at the port to organise entry permits for all those onboard and checking passports and documents for those queuing up to leave. They never left, even as the bombardment came closer to the embassy building, only taking precautions to stay away from windows to avoid flying glass. Arriving in Gaddafi's Libya days before NATO began to bomb the country in March 2011, I saw the same diligence in duty as the Indian team stamped passports, sharing rooms in the Ambassador's residence in Tripoli, which was more secure, even as street battles and gunfire raged outside. In Syria the next year, as the anti-Assad uprising came closer to the capital Damascus, the Indian embassy's diplomats stayed on despite reports that the regime could be overthrown in a violent revolution. With only a skeletal strength of staff, the mission worked the phones to help journalists who had been detained by the Syrian police for unauthorised filming. The Indian Embassy in Kabul lived in precarious times for years, losing two diplomats - Defence Attaché Brigadier Ravi Datt Mehta and diplomat V. Venkateswara Rao - in a suicide bombing right at its gates in 2008. Despite the daily danger, diplomats were evacuated out of Afghanistan only four times in four decades, and many went back in soon after. Most diplomats confine themselves to writing dispatches back to the foreign office, but could easily fill several action-packed thriller books with their experiences, which would be read long after they are gone. As a friend of American diplomat Richard Holbrooke told his biographer, “It would be far better to write a novel about him, than a biography, let alone an obituary.”

PICTURE OF THE WEEK

Smoking out



Fogging on wheels: A worker is engaged in fumigation work to control mosquitoes and combat diseases like dengue and malaria in Lucknow on April 6. SANDEEP SAXENA

FROM THE ARCHIVES

FIFTY YEARS AGO APRIL 10, 1976

HMT to make components for nuclear reactors

Bangalore, April 9: A new division for making components for nuclear reactors would be set up in Bangalore by the Hindustan Machine Tools (HMT) Ltd., its Chairman, Dr. H. M. Patil, disclosed here today. The new project estimated to cost Rs. 2.5 crores was awaiting the Government's sanction, he said. Dr. Patil claimed that in five years from now

The Hindu.

and given the right direction, the HMT's know-how (now being utilised in the Philippines and Sri Lanka) would perhaps see many projects come up in developing countries. The recent UNIDO-HMT workshop on machine tools was a pace-setter in that direction, he said. Dr. Patil said a high-level team from the HMT would be visiting Kenya in connection with the setting up of the machine tool plant at the instance of the Kenya Government. Another project contemplated by the HMT, he said, was for supplying, erecting and commissioning of machine tools for an advanced training centre in Iraq, helping assure Rs. 2.5 crores worth of machine tools.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO APRIL 10, 1926

Baghdad in danger

Baghdad, April 9: The safety of Baghdad is seriously threatened by an unprecedented flood in the Tigris river which has breached near the Royal Palace. The Palace has been evacuated and is surrounded by a fierce torrent. King Faisal, who is away in his country seat a hundred miles away superintending operations in his cotton estate, has been wired for and he is hurriedly returning to Baghdad to-night by special train. Royal ladies have been removed very speedily to the house of Nuri Pasha, Minister of War. The palace gardens present a scene of devastation. A mass of wreckage were whirled round palm trees by the ever-increasing current.

From Page One

Record voter turnout in Puducherry and Assam

After casting his vote, the Kerala Chief Minister asserted that the State's people favour development and believe that only the LDF can take the State forward with commitment. In Kerala, polling took place in 140 Assembly seats with the ruling Left Democratic Front (LDF) looking for a hat-trick in the State.

Leader of the Opposition V.D. Satheesan, on the other hand, reiterated that the Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF) will come to power with more than 100 seats, while BJP State president Rajeev Chandrasekhar said that the National Democratic Alliance (NDA) is confident of winning a majority on its own.

‘Historic’ turnout in Assam

In Assam, the bulk of the State's 2.5 crore voters have sealed the fate of 722 candidates, including 59 women. Officials said voting was largely peaceful, despite reports of violence in a few constituencies, including Khowang and Tamulpur, and allegations of proxy voting at a booth in the Guwahati Central constituency.

“Assam has risen above language and caste. Our people have voted with one clear resolve – to protect our land, our identity, and our culture from illegal infiltration and demographic aggression,” Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma said.

State Congress president Gaurav Gogoi thanked the people of the State for turning out in unprecedented numbers to vote for change. “It is now the responsibility of the Election Commission to ensure the security of the EVMs and to conduct an accurate counting of votes on May 4,” he said.

According to an EC statement, over 2.5 lakh polling staff reached their polling stations on Wednesday night itself. A number of new voter-friendly initiatives were introduced, including easily identifiable colour photos of candidates on EVM ballot papers, mobile deposit facilities, newly designed voter information slips for easy readability, and a limit of 1,200 electors per polling station.

‘India’s FY 27 growth outlook cut to 6.6%’

The India Development Update report is a companion to the South Asia Economic Update 2026. That report had projected growth in South Asia to slow to 6.3% in 2026 from 7% in 2025.

The World Bank's Acting Director for India Paul Procee noted that there are things that can be done to boost growth. “Boosting private sector-led growth will be critical to strengthening economic resilience and supporting more young people to enter the workforce,” Mr. Procee said.

Cross-sector slowdown

The report said that industrial activity is expected to slow to 7.5% in 2026-27 from 8.8% in the previous year. It said that the manufacturing sector – especially electronics, automobiles, and other tradable goods – will prop up industrial growth.

“However, higher input costs and decreased export demand from the Gulf region will weigh on overall industrial growth,” the report said. “Business services are likely to be impacted by the global economic slowdown and higher input costs (particularly of LPG) will adversely impact food and accommodation services.”

The report went on to say that there are “substantial downside risks” to its outlook, suggesting that growth could slow further if the conflict in West Asia is prolonged. “Although India can absorb temporary shocks, its reliance on energy imports from the region leaves the external balance, inflation, and fiscal position vulnerable,” the report said. A disrupted labor market in Gulf economies could significantly lower remittances.

Notably, the report further said that, if the government and oil marketing companies continue to shield consumers from the full brunt of higher energy prices through excise rate cuts and increased subsidies, the government's fiscal consolidation efforts could reverse.

Iran ceasefire teeters on Lebanon, Hormuz row

The chief of Iran's nuclear agency said on Thursday that protecting Tehran's right to enrich uranium is “necessary” for progress with the U.S.

Mohammad Eslami, who leads the Atomic Energy Organization of Iran, made the remarks on Thursday to presspersons during commemorations for the late Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei in Tehran. “It is a part of the necessary (things) that nobody speaks about,” Mr. Eslami said, referring to the U.S. refusal to acknowledge enrichment as one part of Iran's 10-point plan.

Iranian news agencies published a chart on Thursday suggesting the country's paramilitary Revolutionary Guard put sea mines into the strait during the war. The chart showed a large circle marked “danger zone” in Farsi over the route ships take through the strait, through which 20% of all traded oil and natural gas once passed.

Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif on Thursday met with the country's Army chief, Field Marshal Asim Munir, who jointly “appreciated the restraint demonstrated by all sides”. Pakistan's premier spoke on Thursday to his Lebanese counterpart, Nawaf Salam, and “strongly condemned Israel's ongoing aggression against Lebanon”, the Prime Minister's Office said.

Manipur blast: family calls for arrest of perpetrators

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Two days after two children in Manipur were killed in an alleged bomb attack on the house of a Meitei family in Bishnupur, the children's grandfather on Thursday virtually addressed a press conference, calling for the immediate arrest of the perpetrators, who he believed were “Kuki militants”.

At the press conference organised by Meitei civil society organisations (CSOs) in New Delhi on Thursday, Oinam Babuton, the paternal grandfather of the children, said, “There has to be an end to Meitei civilians being attacked and killed by these militants.”

The April 7 morning attack on the family's home killed the children in their sleep and seriously injured their mother, a Guwahati-based nurse.

The attack has once again escalated tensions in the State. CSOs, such as the Meitei Heritage Society, Delhi Manipur Society, and others, called for “exemplary punishment” for the perpetrators of this attack, dismantling of the “infrastructure of Kuki militancy”, and fixing accountability for the failure to prevent such attacks.

NIA may probe death of Meitei children in blast

Protests and shutdown continue in Manipur capital and other valley areas; curfew and Internet curbs to remain; CM to request Centre to stop withdrawing security personnel from the State

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

The investigation into the killing of two Meitei children in a “bomb attack” in Manipur's Bishnupur district on April 7 is likely to be handed over to the National Investigation Agency (NIA), a senior government official said on Thursday. Their father is a Border Security Force (BSF) jawan.

The official said the attackers had not been identified so far and all aspects were being looked into.

At a unified command meeting chaired by Chief Minister Yumnam Khemchand Singh on April 8, it was decided that curfew would continue in the valley districts. Security forces and police were asked to be more visible on the streets.

The meeting discussed the protection of properties and residences of MLAs, which may be targeted by the local people.

The State government is likely to request the Union Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) to halt the withdrawal of 70 companies of Central Armed Police Forces (CAPF) – around 7,000 personnel – for election-



Security personnel stand guard as protesters attempt to enter CM's bungalow, following the killing of two children, on Thursday. ANI

related deployment in other States.

In the past few days, around 40 CAPF companies have been withdrawn from Manipur.

A total shutdown was observed on Thursday in the valley areas, including Imphal, and rallies were organised to protest the killings. Internet remained suspended for the third consecutive day.

Mob attack
Following the killings at Tronglaobi, a mob stormed a Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) camp at Gelmol, over one km

the armoury that the CRPF personnel opened fire, leading to the death of three civilians.

The official said that the bomb that killed the children and left their mother grievously injured was locally assembled.

Another unexploded device – a galvanised iron pipe with the tip of a factory-made rocket head affixed to it and wires dangling from the sides – was defused by the Manipur Police and sent for forensic examination.

‘Intensify operations’
“The make of the explosive device is not established yet. It is not clear if the attackers came from the hillside or the attack was outsourced to someone in the vicinity. All angles are being explored. It may be a ploy to undermine the efforts of the new Chief Minister to bring all the communities together,” said the official.

Security forces have been asked to intensify operations against the United Kuki National Army (UKNA), an insurgent group active in Henglep subdivision, south west of Churachandpur district since 2015.

Privileges committee asks Kamra to give apology

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

Stand-up comedian Kunal Kamra was cross-questioned by the Privileges Committee of the Maharashtra Legislature on Thursday in a breach-of-privilege matter being examined against him.

He was asked 24 questions during the one-hour proceedings, and was told that the matter will be looked at differently, if he tendered an unconditional apology. Mr. Kamra later told *The Hindu* that he had refused to tender an unconditional apology.

He had appeared before the committee a few times before this. The last time, the matter was postponed after Shiv Sena (UBT) leader Sushama Andhare had sought an extension. A breach-of-privilege motion has been moved against both of them for their comments against Maharashtra Deputy Chief Minister Eknath Shinde.

“Cross questioning of Pravin Darekar and Kunal Kamra took place today. (BJP leader Pravin Darekar had moved the motion against Mr Kamra). We have told him that if he tenders an unconditional apology, the committee will think of this differently,” head of privileges committee Prasad Lad said.

Government notifies CAPF law; families protest, say it undermines rights of forces

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

On a day when the families of Central Armed Police Force (CAPF) personnel protested at the Rajghat against the passing of the CAPF (General Administration) Bill, 2026, by Parliament on April 2, the President gave it her assent. Subsequently the CAPF, General Administration Act, 2026 was notified in the Gazette of India.

The protesters stated that certain provisions of the Bill undermined the rights and service conditions of the forces that had served for decades as the first line of defence in safeguarding India's internal security and borders. Retired CAPF personnel and their families, and the wives of several serving officers turned up for the protest with their children.



Members of All Ex Paramilitary Forces welfare Association stage a protest against CAPF Bill 2026 on March 23. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

Families present at the Rajghat said that other than the Bill they were protesting the neglect of their demands – such as restoration of the Old Pension Scheme, time-bound promotions, uniform service conditions, and dignified career progression.

The Act stated that in all CAPFs, 50% of the total posts in the rank of Inspector-General, at least 67% in the rank of Additional Di-

rector-General and all posts in the rank of Special Director-General and Director-General shall be filled by IPS officers on deputation. Till now, such postings were done based on executive orders. The Act will negate a May 23, 2025, Supreme Court order which asked the Home Ministry to “progressively reduce” IPS deputation in CAPFs up to the rank of IGs in the next two years.

If voted to power, Cong. will end ‘discriminatory system’ in CAPF leadership: Rahul

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi on Thursday said the Congress would dismantle the “discriminatory system” that allegedly denies personnel of the Central Armed Police Forces (CAPF) opportunities to rise to top leadership positions, and ensure they receive their “full rights and privileges” when they return to power.

Marking Valour Day of the Central Reserve Police Force, Mr. Gandhi paid tribute to CAPF personnel for safeguarding the country and confronting threats ranging from terrorism to left-wing extremism.

“Your courage and sacrifice safeguard our nation every single day. Stationed at our borders, you keep the country secure;



you confront the threats of terrorism and Naxalism; and you ensure that our elections remain peaceful and safe,” the Congress leader said on X.

“Despite years of sacrifice and arduous service, CAPF personnel receive neither timely promotions nor the right to lead their own force simply because the top leadership positions are reserved for individuals from outside the organisation,” he said.

Mr. Gandhi said personnel within the forces possess “specialised training, invaluable ground-level experience, and deep strategic insight”, and maintained that in the interest of national security, such forces should be led by officers drawn from within the system.

Calling it an issue of “justice and dignity”, Mr. Gandhi said long-pending concerns over promotions, pay, welfare and leadership opportunities had undermined morale within the forces. “Upon forming the government, we will dismantle this discriminatory system...,” he said.

His remarks came days after Parliament cleared a Bill aimed at creating a unified legal framework governing personnel across different CAPFs, replacing the current set of separate service-rule regimes.

Cong. opts out of byelection in Baramati after ‘appeals’

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

Maharashtra Congress president Harshwardhan Sakpal on Thursday announced that the party will not contest the Baramati Assembly byelection.

The bypoll to be held on April 23 was necessitated by the death of Ajit Pawar, then Maharashtra Deputy Chief Minister. His wife, Sunetra Pawar, now the Deputy Chief Minister, is set to contest the election as the Mahayuti candidate.

Owing to “emotional appeals” from the leaders of NCP as well as the NCP (SP), Congress is withdrawing its candidate Akash More, Mr. Sakpal said.

Congress leaders to meet for discussing women’s quota amendments, delimitation

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress has convened a meeting of its top decision-making body, the Congress Working Committee (CWC), on Friday to deliberate on the Centre's move to amend the women's reservation law, the proposed delimitation exercise, and developments in West Asia.

The meeting will be held at 3 p.m. at the party's Indira Bhavan headquarters and is expected to be attended by senior leaders. The CWC will discuss the political and constitutional implications of the proposed changes, including

The meeting comes ahead of a three-day sitting of Parliament for introducing the women's quota Bill

the planned delimitation of parliamentary constituencies. The deliberations come days ahead of a three-day sitting of the Parliament during which the government is expected to introduce legislation to operationalise the women's reservation law before the 2029 Lok Sabha elections and to increase the strength of the Lok Sabha to 816 seats, with 273 seats reserved for women.

Last week, Congress communication chief Jairam Ramesh warned that a rushed delimitation process could have “dangerous consequences”.

Mr. Ramesh said the party did not want any disturbance in the existing balance of representation among States and cautioned against haste in amending constitutional provisions governing the delimitation of parliamentary and Assembly constituencies.

The CWC is also expected to review the evolving security situation in West Asia, including the recently announced two-week ceasefire.

CBI opposes plea to make judge recuse in liquor case

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) on Thursday informed the Delhi High Court that former Chief Minister Arvind Kejriwal and other discharged accused in the liquor policy case cannot seek the recusal of Justice Swarana

Kanta Sharma merely because she attended a “legal seminar” by the Akhil Bharatiya Adhivakta Parishad.

The agency said, “If attending a function of ABAP shows ideological bias of any judge then large number of sitting High Court and Supreme Court judges would have to recuse from hearing any case”.



Baby Raj Ghosh, Manipal Hospitals, Hospital No.MH017907535, 12 months is suffering from Congenital Heart Disease Situs Ambiguus, Intracardiac TAPVC, common complete unbalanced AVSD, No AVIR, Severe PS, D Malposed GAs. He requires to undergo early TAPVC Repair + Bilateral BDG surgery. The Estimated cost of the surgery is Rs.5, 50,000/-.

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APPEAL



ASSEMBLY POLLS



Queuing up: Voters waiting to cast their ballots at a polling booth in Kalamassery, Kerala on Thursday. R. K. NITHIN



Come rain or shine: People lining up with umbrellas at a polling booth in Guwahati, Assam on Thursday. RITU RAJ KONWAR



Duty calls: A women carrying her child while casting her vote at a government primary school in Puducherry on Thursday. R. RAGU



Ride for rights: Voters travelling on a boat across the Brahmaputra to vote in Darrang district of Assam on Thursday. AFP



People waiting to submit their petitions before a special tribunal after their names were deleted from final voter list in Nadia district on Wednesday. PTI

Of 90 lakh voters excluded by SIR in Bengal, 63% are Hindus, 34% are Muslims

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

Muslim voters account for more than a third of the 90 lakh names removed from West Bengal's electoral rolls during the course of the special intensive revision (SIR) process, disproportionately higher than their share of the State's population.

A comparison of booth-level data before and after the SIR shows that 57.47 lakh, or 63%, of the deleted voters are Hindus, while 31.1 lakh, or 34%, are Muslims. This figure assumes significance because Muslims accounted for only 27% of the State's population as per the last census in 2011. In absolute terms, however, Hindus account for the largest number of deletions.

Except for the Bharatiya Janata Party, all political parties in West Bengal had opposed the SIR. The BJP, however, insisted that the process was a drive to sanitise the electoral rolls and remove "illegal infiltrators" from Bangladesh.

High deletions among Matuas

The data on exclusions now show that Hindus faced high deletion rates in certain border constituencies where the majority of the electorate are Matuas. The Matuas are a sect of Hindu namasudras, a Dalit community, who migrated from Bangladesh in large numbers and are being promised citizenship by the BJP under the Citizenship Amendment Act.

For instance, in the Bagda constituency in North 24 Parganas district, 50,230 voters were deleted, of which 46,826 are Hindus and 3,264 Muslims. At Bongaon Uttar in the same district, 42,164 voters have been deleted: 37,101 Hindus and 4,310 Muslims.

In Bhabanipur, there were 50,987 deletions, of which 37,227 are Hindus and 12,084 are Muslims.

In certain districts of the Jangalmahal region where the population of Muslims is low, Hindus account for almost 90% of the deletions. In Jhargram, about 94% of the electorate excluded from the electoral rolls is Hindu. They account for 91% of deletions in Bankura, and 88% of deletions in Purulia as well.

While 63 lakh voters were dropped from the draft rolls published by the EC on February 28, another 60 lakh faced adjudication by judicial officers. Of these, 27 lakh electors were excluded on April 6, taking the total number of deletions to over 90 lakh. Of those deleted during the adjudication process, the highest numbers were in Muslim-dominated districts.

Murshidabad, the district with the highest percentage of Muslims in the State, also recorded the highest deletions of electors under adjudication, with over 4.55 lakh excluded from the 11.01 lakh names which went for judicial scrutiny. North 24 Parganas saw the deletion of 3.25 lakh electors during the adjudication process, followed by Malda, another Muslim-dominated district, with 2.39 lakh deletions. In terms of voters deleted during adjudication, there were more deletions among Muslim voters than Hindus in constituencies such as Bhabanipur and Nandigram.

The West Bengal electorate stands at 6.75 crore voters, significantly lower than the 7.66 crore voters on the rolls before the SIR began in October 2025.

From the margins to momentum: the BJP's electoral journey in Tamil Nadu

Party initially capitalised on Hindutva politics in Kanniyakumari, winning its first Assembly seat in 1996; thereafter it tasted success only in alliance; after the passing of Dravidian stalwarts, it has gained momentum in State's political discourse and hopes to convert its rising vote share to more seats

IN FOCUS

N. Sai Charan
CHENNAI

The BJP has struggled to establish a foothold on its own in Tamil Nadu, where politics has been dominated by the Dravidian majors for more than five decades, but the party has gained momentum in the State in recent years.

The BJP was long viewed as a "North Indian" party, with the Dravidian majors, particularly the DMK, carefully constructing a narrative portraying the BJP as a political outsider in the State.

In its initial years, the BJP's presence in Tamil Nadu was limited to certain pockets. It relied heavily on the members and ideological backing of the RSS. A series of communal clashes at Mandaikadu in Kanniyakumari district in 1982 led to considerable demographic polarisation and provided an opening for Hindutva politics in that region. In the 1984 Assembly election, V. Bala-

chandran, an Independent candidate backed by the Hindu Munnani, won the Padmanabhapuram seat with 28,465 votes, defeating M. Vincent of the AIADMK by a margin of 4,317 votes.

Hindutva gains ground

Most BJP candidates polled only several hundred to a few thousand votes in that election, but M.R. Gandhi, who contested from Colachel, secured over 32,000 votes, losing by just 589 votes. This result reflected how Hindutva politics was gaining ground in the district. Mr. Gandhi is now the MLA representing Nagercoil.

The BJP has made repeated attempts to win Padmanabhapuram and other Assembly segments in Kanniyakumari district. C. Velayuthan, a local face of the BJP, tried his luck several times and finally succeeded in 1996, becoming the BJP's first MLA in Tamil Nadu. He defeated the DMK's Bala Janathi-pathy by 4,540 votes, braving a pro-DMK-TMC wave. In the same election, the BJP also secured the se-



Garnering support: Prime Minister Narendra Modi and other BJP leaders greeting supporters in Chennai. FILE PHOTO

cond position in Nagercoil, Colachel, and Killyoor in the district.

By the turn of the millennium, the BJP had tasted more success by aligning with the AIADMK and DMK during the 1998 and 1999 parliamentary polls, respectively. In 2001, joining hands with the DMK, four of its candidates entered the Assembly: H. Raja from Karaikudi, Jaga Veerapandian from Mayiladuthurai, K.V. Muralidharan from Thalli, and K.N. Lakshmanan from Myla-

pore. Contesting 21 seats, the party secured a vote share of 3.19%.

Thereafter, in 2006, contesting in 225 constituencies, it drew a blank, forfeiting deposits in 221 seats. Going alone, the BJP failed to open its account in both 2011 and 2016.

Finally, BJP nominees entered the Assembly again in 2021, in alliance with the AIADMK, winning four out of 20 seats. Former AIADMK Minister and incumbent BJP State president Nainar Nagenthran

Making inroads

The table shows the performance of BJP in Assembly elections in Tamil Nadu

Election	Number of seats contested	Number of seats won	Vote share in %
1980	10	-	0.07
1984	15	-	0.25
1989	31	-	0.35
1991	99	-	1.7
1996	143	1	1.81
2001	21	4	3.19
2006	225	-	2.02
2011	204	-	2.22
2016	188	-	2.84
2021	20	4	2.62

won from Tirunelveli, his home turf, while Mr. Gandhi, Vanathi Srinivasan, and C. Saraswathi won from Nagercoil, Coimbatore (South), and Modakurichi, respectively. The party secured a 2.62% vote share.

Sustained efforts

After the passing of Dravidian stalwarts Jayalalithaa and M. Karunanidhi, the BJP has gained momentum in Tamil Nadu's political discourse. The rise of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the confusions

within the AIADMK, along with the sustained efforts of recent BJP State presidents Tamilisai Soundararajan, L. Murugan, and K. Annamalai, helped the party gain strength.

In the 2024 Lok Sabha election, the BJP formed a third front with parties such as the Pattali Makkal Katchi and Amma Makkal Munnetra Kazhagam, acting as an alternative to the Dravidian majors. The BJP polled 11.24% of the vote, but failed to win any seats. In fact, BJP candidates were not even able to secure a lead in any of the Assembly segments.

In the 2026 Assembly polls, the party has been allocated 27 seats as part of the AIADMK-led NDA. With Tamil Maanila Congress (Moopanar) and Tamilaga Makkal Munnetra Kazhagam contesting on the BJP's symbol, the total number of official BJP nominees goes up to 33. This is the highest number of seats ever contested by the party as part of an alliance with the Dravidian majors, and it is now hoping it can convert its momentum to better its representation.

BJP and the shifting political balance in Kerala

Varghese K. George
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The BJP's emergence has turned around Kerala's political balance, as indicated in the following two facts.

First, traditional regional rivals, the Congress-led UDF and the CPI-M-led LDF, are defining their contest with reference to the BJP. Each accuse the other of being weak in fighting the BJP or even colluding with it. The BJP, meanwhile, says the UDF and the LDF are in a fake fight in Kerala while they are partners everywhere else across the country.

Second, all three formations agree on a key question that roiled the State's politics over the past eight years, stirring a Hindu consciousness: the entry of women of menstruating age into the Sabarimala shrine. All three now agree that they should not be entering. As the Supreme Court took up a batch of petitions that will revisit its earlier Sabarimala verdict that allowed the entry of women of menstruating age, Kerala's LDF government and the BJP government at the Centre took similar views, favouring a continuation of the practice. The LDF has abandoned its strident position in favour of women's entry, in response to the strong backlash among Hindu communities.

The emergence of an identifiable Hindu vote is unmistakable in the State, but how that will influence the electoral dynamics remains an open question.



Gaining ground: BJP supporters on the final day of campaigning for the Assembly election in Thiruvananthapuram. PTI

The performance of the BJP in recent elections provides context. Its vote share fell from 16% in the 2016 Assembly election to 11.5% in the 2021 Assembly election, before recovering to 16.7% in the 2024 Lok Sabha election. It won its first Assembly seat in 2016, when O. Rajagopal won from Nedom, but lost it in 2021. In the 2024 Lok Sabha election, the BJP won the Thrissur seat and came second in Thiruvananthapuram and Attingal, while also finishing second in Assembly segments across Alappuzha.

The community composition of the State is the biggest speed-breaker for the BJP. According to the 2011 Census, Kerala has 54.7% Hindus, 26.6% Muslims and 18.4% Christians, who are split across multiple denominations. The BJP is banking on an apparent tension between Christians and Muslims to make its way in the State. The party has fielded several leaders from the commun-

ity. Campaigning for Anoop Antony Joseph, the BJP candidate in Thiruvalla – a region of Syrian Christian influence – Prime Minister Narendra Modi said the Hindus and Christians were victims of communal fanaticism, asking them to unite.

Avoiding a split

The UDF's chances are dependent on its success in avoiding a split between its Christian and Muslim supporters, while stopping an erosion of its Hindu voters. Christians are sceptical of the influence of the Indian Union Muslim League (IUML) within the UDF. There are demographic and economic reasons for the tensions. The birth rates among Christians and Hindus are lower than those of Muslims in the State. While a large number of Christian and Hindu youth are migrating permanently to the West, the migration of Muslims is temporary. Christian community leaders lament

property alienation and the expanding presence of Muslims in local businesses in traditional strongholds. Sensing the danger of a Christian-Muslim split, the IUML has said it would not be looking for the post of Deputy Chief Minister or making any specific claims over portfolios or ministerial berths.

The Congress and the UDF both have too many leaders and too few workers – a situation at least partly explained by the population decline in the State, which is ageing and losing people to migration. The shrinkage of party activists is affecting the Congress the most, but the Left is also not unaffected.

In 2021, Pinarayi Vijayan was the beneficiary of the social realignments in the State. The CPI(M) made up for the loss of its Hindu voters to the BJP by roping in considerable segments of Christians and Muslims in southern districts, and won an unprecedented second term. The UDF ended up as the loser. This time, the dynamics are different. Mr. Vijayan and the LDF are focused on reconstituting their traditional Hindu votes. Not only has the government changed its views on Sabarimala with regard to women, it also organised a convention of devotees, attended by Mr. Vijayan. A letter from Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath was read out at the event by a Kerala Minister. SNDP Yogam leader Vellappally Natesan, who repeatedly makes anti-Muslim jibes, is rooting for Mr. Vijayan in this election.

Given the criss-crossing of communities across the three formations, it is difficult to anticipate the numerical outcome – both the LDF and the UDF were losing some of their voters to the BJP, while the LDF was also gaining some from the UDF. The BJP was growing in previous elections, but that is no guarantee that it will continue to grow. The BJP's upward trajectory was abruptly disrupted by the proposed amendments to the FCRA – the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act. In Kerala, where Church-run hospitals, schools, and social welfare institutions have historically depended on foreign contributions, the move is widely seen as specially targeting the Christian community. The Centre put the Bill on hold ahead of the elections, but the damage had been done.

There is a possibility that voting will be more polarised than recent elections suggest. Every election gets framed on a particular question, once the campaign meanders through multiple appeasements. The LDF has framed these elections as a mandate for a third consecutive term, without naming Mr. Vijayan as the next Chief Minister. The UDF has framed it as a contest to decide whether Mr. Vijayan should be given a third consecutive term. If the voting gets framed on those lines, it will be a bipolar contest, in which the BJP will be marginalised. At any rate, the BJP is the known unknown of Kerala.

AJUP chief took money from BJP: Trinamool

Shrabana Chatterjee
KOLKATA

The Trinamool Congress on Thursday alleged that Aam Janata Unnayan Party (AJUP) chief Humayun Kabir took money from the Bharatiya Janata Party to "plot and mislead" Muslims of West Bengal.

The party shared viral stinging operation videos from a conversation between Mr. Kabir and an unidentified man.

The video shared by the Trinamool has a time stamp marked December 19, 2025, in which, Mr. Kabir, who formed the AJUP after being suspended from the Trinamool, was seen speaking to a man not visible on camera. Mr. Kabir was saying that he has a "covert" understanding with the BJP's Suwendu Adhikari that if he manages to secure 70-80 seats and the BJP gets around 100-120 seats in the Assembly polls, Mr. Kabir will offer his support to the BJP to form government and in turn they will make Mr. Kabir the Deputy Chief Minister.

The video has not been individually authenticated or verified by *The Hindu*. Mr. Kabir denied all the allegations and said if the Trinamool had the courage then it should prove their allegations.

"If they cannot prove their allegations, I will file a ₹2,000 crore defamation case against them," the leader said.

M CH-CHE

INBRIEF



Two India-bound ships among a few transiting strait on Day 2

On Day 2 of ceasefire, ship traffic across Strait of Hormuz, which had slowly increased to 10% of pre-war levels before ceasefire, dwindled to a handful that included two India-bound vessels. With direct talks between Iran and the U.S. scheduled to begin soon in Pakistan, shippers await clarity on the protocols for the transit agreed to by all the stakeholders. Ship tracker websites show that Marivex, an oil tanker with a cargo capacity of 12,800 tonnes, is carrying oil from Bandar Abbas in Iran to New Mangalore Port. MSG, an oil tanker of 7,000 tonnes cargo capacity, is carrying cargo from UAE to India. Both transited the strait late on April 9. Erik Grundt, Senior Analyst at Rystad Energy, talked about how a high-priced contract for cargo on a very large crude carrier likely in the Persian Gulf was considered but cancelled soon after because of uncertainty. On Thursday, Nour News, an Iranian news website linked to the Supreme National Security Council of the country, published a navigation chart with markings showing two channels close to the Iranian coast that ships entering and exiting the strait should take so as to avoid colliding with anti-ship mines.

‘Q4 PAT of Nifty firms will be under pressure due to war’

Net profit of Nifty 50 firms for the fourth quarter of fiscal 2026 is expected to slow down on a year-on year basis due to the price effects of Iran-U.S. war, analysts said. Profit after tax (PAT) of Nifty 50 companies is expected to grow between 0.6% and 6% for the recently concluded quarter going by reports. Elara, while not giving an earnings forecast for Nifty 50, said for the companies in its data coverage, the PAT would grow just by 0.6% in Q4 FY26 as against 0.4% in the same period last year. Motilal Oswal Financial Services report estimated a 6% increase on a year-on-year basis, while Kotak Institutional was far more conservative, forecasting a meagre 2.6% growth rate. According to the Kotak note, this rate of growth is still better than that of Q4 FY25, when the PAT declined 3%. The past two years have been painful for corporate India as compared with the March quarter of fiscal 2024, when the PAT of Nifty 50 increased 7.9% on a year-on-year basis, Kotak said.

Reining in medicine prices despite war impact on inputs, says official

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI

A senior official in India’s Ministry of Chemicals & Fertilizers said there has been no major rise in prices of pharmaceutical drugs despite the West Asia war impacting global supply chains of some essential inputs, particularly solvents and active pharmaceutical ingredients (APIs).

The Centre has taken note of the disruptions and devising strategies to meet the challenges, Joint Secretary in the Department of Pharmaceuticals Satyaprakash T. L. said, adding propylene, ammonia and



The Centre is working to ensure continuous flow of inputs.

methanol were the key solvents the pharmaceutical industry needs and whose supplies have been affected. Butanol is needed in smaller quantities for certain antibiotics. Propylene

remains the most critical input since it is used in Isopropyl Alcohol (IPA) and Isobutyl Benzene production, which are used in medicines such as Ibuprofen. A significant share of propylene supply is being met through BPCL’s Kochi and Mumbai refineries and supplied to major manufacturers of Isopropyl Alcohol.

Uninterrupted supply The Ministry and the Department are working in coordination with the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas to ensure uninterrupted availability of essential inputs for pharma-

ceutical manufacturing, the official said at an inter-ministerial briefing. With methanol supply emerging as an area of concern, Assam Petrochemicals and Gujarat Narmada Valley Fertilizers & Chemicals (GNFC) agreed to supply adequate quantities. Availability of methylated ammonium products, used as intermediates for medicines, is being closely monitored, he said. Supplies of aluminium for pharmaceutical packaging faced constraints. Restoration of the supply is ‘underway’ and expected to normalise within a week, he said.

TCS Q4 net up 12% to ₹13,718 cr., board okays ₹31 final dividend

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

Tata Consultancy Services Ltd. (TCS) net profit for the fourth quarter ended March 31 rose 12% year-on-year to ₹13,718 crore. For FY26, net profit was up 1.35% to ₹49,210 crore. The board recommended a final dividend of ₹31/share. The total dividend payout in FY26 was estimated at ₹39,571 crore. In Q4, revenue rose 9.64% to ₹70,698 crore. Annual revenue grew 4.58% to ₹2,67,021 crore.

But a 2.4% dip in constant currency terms. FY26 operating margin at 25% grew 70 basis points, the highest in four years, TCS said. **Salary increases** Having laid off thousands of people last year TCS said it implemented annual salary increases across all grades effective April 1. As on March 31, the head count was 5,84,519. In a note Equirus Securities said in FY26 headcount slid by 23,460 (3.9% dip). During Q4, growth was led by BFSI (31.1%).

In Q4 region wise in constant currency terms North America grew 2.5%. CEO and MD K. Krithivasan said “This is the third consecutive quarter of sequential growth, supported by three mega deals and a \$12 billion Total Contract Value (TCV), underscoring the strength of five pillar strategy and our AI led positioning across services.” Aarthi Subramanian, ED, president and COO, said “In Q4, our annualised AI revenue surpassed \$2.3 billion on accelerated deployment of AI solutions.”

Apollo Micro completes blast trials for Limpet mines

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

Apollo Micro Systems shares surged Thursday on the back of the defence tech firm announcing successful completion of blast trials for Limpet mines. “Limpet mines are used in naval defence. We are the only Indian firm to have successfully developed the product for Indian Navy,” it said. Shares closed 11.83% higher at ₹232.55 apiece on the BSE.

Business

Govt., IT sector studying Anthropic model’s cybersecurity implications

Claude’s new LLM has found security vulnerabilities over a decade old in widely used software; as large U.S. firms get early access, Indian firms, IT Ministry are examining what lies ahead; experts flag ramifications of such models’ availability to all

Aroon Deep
NEW DELHI

The Indian IT industry and the Union government are studying the ramifications of Claude Mythos, Anthropic’s unreleased model that has been billed as a powerful scanner - and potentially a vector - of undiscovered security vulnerabilities across the world’s most widely used computer systems.

The Hindu has learnt that officials in the Electronics and Information Technology Ministry and at the Computer Emergency Response Team, India (CERT-in) are deliberating what Mythos’s capabilities could mean in the coming days, even as a consortium of American firms, in partnership with Anthropic, rushes to patch software vulnerabilities that human cybersecurity experts have not hitherto spotted or fixed. Word of Mythos has spread rapidly in cybersecurity circles since the announcement of Project Glasswing, a consortium of 40 companies and open-source code maintainers to whom Anthropic is giving early access of the LLM, with a \$100 million budget to perform scans of the vast codebases that power other IT systems around the world, including in India.

Anthropic said it has already found several vulnerabilities in softwares such as OpenBSD, FFMPEG and the Linux kernel, systems that are deeply embedded in computers and servers globally, spurring the firm to work with their developers as much as possible in patching bugs before making the model public.

The task masters

A consortium of U.S. firms and Anthropic are rushing to patch software vulnerabilities human experts have not fixed



■ Project Glasswing is a consortium of 40 companies and open-source code maintainers to whom Anthropic is giving early access of the LLM

■ This involves a \$100 million budget to perform scans of vast codebases that power other IT systems around the world, including India

No Indian firm appears in the partial list of partners that Anthropic published. This does not mean, however, that Project Glasswing will not benefit Indian firms at all. Since IT firms generally use a “tech stack” that combines hardware and software from a variety of vendors, including several products from Glasswing partners, it is likely that patches being released in the coming days will close off certain security gaps in Indian firms.

‘Entire tsunami’

“The more relevant question is whether Indian firms are investing enough in their own security posture on top of that shared infrastructure, because that part is entirely on them,” Pawan Prabhat, a co-founder of the LLM deployment startup Shorthills AI, told *The Hindu*.

As such, the IT enterprise services (ITeS) industry may be anxious to be a bigger part of the conversation that Anthropic is having, since systems integrators tend to craft bespoke code for customers, which may suddenly be at risk of being targeted by novel infiltration techniques when Mythos and more powerful models become available to the public. Infosys,

which announced a partnership with Anthropic during the AI Impact Summit, declined to comment on whether it was a Glasswing partner due to its financial reporting silence period.

Vinayak Godse, the CEO of the Data Security Council of India (DSCI) under Nasscom, the main cybersecurity forum for the Indian IT industry, told *The Hindu* in a telephonic interview from Singapore that the council has been holding meetings with different verticals of IT firms in India to get a handle on the unfolding situation. Mr. Godse welcomed Glasswing as an initiative, hailing Anthropic as a “responsible” player for not releasing it just yet.

“If something happened to the underlying core infrastructure (like a router made by Cisco, for example), the impact will be catastrophic,” he said.

Mr. Godse pointed to a particularly vulnerable group: product companies. “Imagine if this model is available for everyone to use, what happens to the entire Software-as-a-Service (SaaS) plus deep tech product ecosystem across the globe,” he asked.

The latter, he said, “is not only of systems but, pre-

sent in the physical world: systems like Supervisory Control and Data Acquisition (SCADA) systems [used in manufacturing and public utilities setups], internet of things (IoT) systems, and so on.”

“It’s an entire tsunami coming in,” Mr. Godse said.

DSCI declined to comment whether it was having any India-focused conversations with Anthropic, which has an office in Bengaluru. In absolute numbers, India is Anthropic’s second largest market. The firm, which did not respond to a query by *The Hindu* on the role planned for Indian firms in Project Glasswing, has shot to prominence in recent months due to its extremely software-capable LLMs.

Those capabilities have impacted Indian IT firms’ stock prices, even as the government encourages Indian firms to move fast on deploying AI.

Soft targets

Government IT systems could be especially vulnerable to attacks, as their security readiness varies widely between different Ministries, States and departments. But Mr. Godse said that he was confident that CERT-in and government departments would be able to respond quickly to threats, as he assessed the state response to widespread attacks on government servers last year during the India-Pakistan conflict as a positive signal.

“Government systems like Aadhaar and GST run on older codebases,” pointed out Srinivas Padmanabhuni, the chief technology officer at the LLM testing firm AiEnsured. “These are exactly the kinds of systems where

Mythos has already demonstrated the ability to find vulnerabilities that stayed hidden for decades.” Mr. Prabhat of Shorthills AI said that government systems “might not be of primary interest to professional hackers who are in it for financial gain, but inimical states are a different matter.”

For firms that position themselves as indigenous alternatives to foreign tech stacks, Mythos turns up an unenviable dilemma: should they act to subject their systems to an audit by an American LLM, or risk the consequences of holding off on hardening their systems with Mythos-level tools?

Indians have typically excelled in spotting security vulnerabilities, with researchers chasing “bug bounties” to find serious vulnerabilities, which when disclosed to tech firms can fetch a handsome financial reward.

Mr. Godse noted that this group of researchers may see their work impacted by Mythos. Mythos’s long-term impact could also hinge on the outcome of a longstanding cybersecurity debate: are software vulnerabilities “dense” or “sparse”? In other words, are there infinitely many vulnerabilities in code that are just waiting for a way to be exploited by attackers, or are they rare chinks in otherwise solid armour?

Nicholas Carlini, an Anthropic researcher, was asked about this debate after a talk in March where he laid out the performance of Opus, the most powerful Claude model available to the public, in finding bugs. It performed shockingly well, he said in its presentation.

Indian team to visit U.S. this month to discuss trade deal currently stuck in limbo

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

A team of negotiators from India will be visiting the U.S. later this month to discuss the interim trade deal between the two countries, which currently lies in limbo, the Ministry of Commerce and Industry has confirmed to *The Hindu*. U.S. Ambassador Sergio Gor posted a similar message on X, as well.

India and the U.S. in early February 2026 issued a joint statement saying they have agreed on a framework for an interim trade deal. The deal itself was to have been signed in March, and come into effect by April. However, soon after the announcement, the U.S. Supreme Court invalidated the reciprocal tariffs levied by U.S. President Donald Trump.

Following this, the U.S. launched various trade and labour related investigations on several economies, including India. The U.S. can theoretically levy tariffs on other countries on the basis of these investigations, once they are concluded. A timeline for completion has not yet been revealed.

U.S. Ambassador to India Sergio Gor on Thursday posted on X that he had had a “highly productive” meeting with U.S. Trade Representative Jamieson Greer to discuss “advancing Mr. Trump’s trade priorities in South and Central Asia”.

When asked, the spokesperson of the Ministry of Commerce and Industry confirmed to *The Hindu* that this trip would be happening, but added that the “details are being worked out”.

The Kerala Minerals & Metals Ltd
(A Govt. of Kerala Undertaking) Sankaramangalam, Kollam - 691583
Phone : +91-476-361215 to 217, E-mail : mml@kmmll.com, URL : www.kmmll.com

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No	Tender ID	Items
1.	2026_KMML_848310_1	Supply of Electric Hoists of various capacities
2.	2026_KMML_848309_1	Supply of Key Bricks

Chavara. 10.04.2026 Sd/ Managing Director for The Kerala Minerals and Metals Ltd

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S.No./MCJ Vikash/2025-26/03 Date :- 02.04.2026
RFP NIT No. 34/2025-26 RFP No. DLB2627RFP0001

Online Technical and Financial Bids in Single Stage two envelopes are invited by Municipal Council Jaisalmer. Details may be seen at our office or at the website of the State Public Procurement Portal <http://sppp.rajjasthan.gov.in>, <http://eproc.rajjasthan.gov.in> and may be downloaded from these websites from. **DLB2627RFP0001**
Raj.Samwad/C/26/497 Commissioner

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NIT No. :- USCL/2025-27/012 Date :- 06/04/2026

NIT Amendment Order

A NIT No. USCL/2025-26/718 was published dated 16.03.2026 for the “Project Management Consultant for Assisting Udaipur Smart City Limited in the Design, Development, Management, and Implementation of USCL Projects, Udaipur.” of Rs. 242.68 Lac with UBN No. UNP2526SLOB00172. The bid submission date has been extended up to 15-04-2026, 02:00 PM for interested bidders. Other details of pre-bid clarification and amendment the bid can be accessed on the State Procurement Portals (<http://eproc.rajjasthan.gov.in> and <http://sppp.raj.nic.in>).

Raj.Samwad/C/26/437 Financial Advisor

राजस्थान सरकार
कोशल, नियोजन एवं उद्यमिता विभाग,
प्राथमिक शिक्षा निदेशालय, राजस्थान, जोधपुर
W-6, गौरव-पथ, जोधपुर

Ph.: 0291-2432290, FAX:- 0291-2632339, E-mail- scheme.dot@rajasthan.gov.in
No.: DTE/T-4(SCHEME)/PMPEs/4324(3)/2026/60806 दिनांक: 03.04.2026

Corrigendum-III
ई-निविदा सूचना संख्या 01/2025-26 में निम्नवृत्त संशोधन किये जा रहे हैं:-

S. No.	UBN No.	Corrigendum and Addendum
01	UBN No.: TET2526SLOB00140, TET2526SLOB00141, TET2526SLOB00142, TET2526SLOB00143, TET2526SLOB00144, TET2526SLOB00145, TET2526SLOB00146, TET2526SLOB00147	RFP में निम्नानुसार आवश्यक संशोधन किये जा रहे हैं:- बिंदु संख्या 01 से 13 तक (संलग्न), Addendum- Shareholder Agreement and License Agreement.

अन्य नियम एवं शर्तें कृपया पढ़ें।
DIPRC/6590/2026 निदेशक (प्रशिक्षण)

BHARAT DYNAMICS LIMITED
(A Government of India Enterprise)
MINISTRY OF DEFENCE
GACHIBOWLI, HYDERABAD-500032

Ref:BDL/CG/OT/GT/013/2025-26 Dt: 10.04.2026

e-PROCUREMENT ABRIDGED TENDER NOTICE
Inviting Indigenous Competitive Bidding

Sl.No.	Tender ID	Description	Estimate in Rs.
1.	66840	Annual rate contract for maintenance and minor civil works at BDL kanchanbagh, Hyderabad	80 Lakhs

Please visit website <https://bdtenders.abeprocure.com>, select online tenders on dashboard for further details. Bids should be submitted online only. “Corrigendum if any shall be issued through our e-portal only and not in Newspapers”
*Bidders are Requested to apply for online Vendor Registration in BDL website <https://bdl-india.in/registration-contractors> prospects.

Additional General Manager (Corp Comm)

कार्यालय अतिरिक्त मुख्य अभियंता, सार्वजनिक निर्माण विभाग, संभाग, अजमेर
ब्रम्हा-राजपुर / अज. / रा. / एम-2600ए निविदा / जी-13 दिनांक:-02.04.2026

NIB No.- PWD2627A0033
UBN No.-PWD2627WLOB00118

निविदा सूचना संख्या 01 एवं 2026-2027

राजस्थान के राजस्थान सरकार की ओर से पोस्ट ऑफिसीयलेशन प्रणालि के अनुसार नगरीय जिले में एक सड़क कार्य के लिए उपर्युक्त केनी में सार्वजनिक निर्माण विभाग, राजस्थान में सड़कजाल अर्थात् राज्य सरकार के अन्य विभागों / केन्द्र सरकार के अधीनस्थ संस्थानों / केन्द्रीय सेवा निर्माण विभाग / कक्षा एनएम दूर संचार विभाग / रेलवे इत्यादि में सड़कजाल एवं केनी के संदर्भा में के निर्धारित प्रथम में ई-प्रोक्चरमेंट प्रणालि के माध्यम से ऑन लाईन निविदा प्रपन की जावेगी। ई-निविदा से संबंधित विवरण वेबसाइट <http://eproc.rajjasthan.gov.in> एवं <http://sppp.rajjasthan.gov.in> पर देखा जा सकता है।

(ई हस्ताक्षर)
अतिरिक्त मुख्य अभियंता,
सा.नि.वि. संभाग, अजमेर।

DIPRC/6554/2026

RajKOMP Info Services Limited (RISL)
C-Block, 1st Floor, Yojana Bhawan, Tilak Marg, C-Scheme, Jaipur

RISL invites e-bids from the eligible bidders for the following:

NIB No./ Unique bid no.	Particulars	Estimated Cost	Start of sale / Last date
ML-130/07.04.2026/ RIS2627WLOB00002	RFP for Rate Contract for Establishment of District Emergency Operation Centre at 13 District of Rajasthan. (Ajmer & Jaipur Zone)	Rs. 7.90 Cr. Rs. 15,80,000/-	10.04.2026/ 01.05.2026

Details can be seen on the websites <http://risl.rajjasthan.gov.in>, <http://sppp.rajjasthan.gov.in>, <http://doitc.rajjasthan.gov.in>. Bids are to be submitted through <http://eproc.rajjasthan.gov.in>

Raj.Samwad/C/26/559 EE (Civil), DoIT&C

अजमेर विकास प्राधिकरण, अजमेर
राजस्थान, जिला जयपुर, अजमेर, Email :- ajmerdeva@gmail.com,
Website :- www.rajjasthan.gov.in/ada, Tel.No. :- 0145-2627748-2627749

क्रमांक :- अजिआ/उ.2/राजनी/2026-27/राजमा 21336666 दिनांक :- 06/04/2026

E-TENDER - 59/ 2025-26

Bids for Providing and Fixing HVAC System in Surgical Block JLN Hospital, Ajmer amounting Rs. 649.74 Lacs are invited from interested bidders for up to 22.04.2026, 6:00 pm. Other particulars of the bid may be visited on procurement portal (<http://eproc.rajjasthan.gov.in>) & (<http://sppp.raj.nic.in>) <http://www.urban.rajjasthan.gov.in/ada> departmental website.

UBN : AJD2627WLOB00001
Raj.Samwad/C/26/578 Executive Engineer

Additional Chief Engineer
Public Health Engineering Department Region-I
Jyoti Nagar, Sakkar Marg, Jaipur
Office: ajr.phed@rajasthan.gov.in
Date :- 06.04.2026

CORRIGENDUM/ADDENDUM NO. 02
Notice Inviting Bid No. 03/2025-26

In continuation to this office NIT No. 03/2025-2026, issued vide this office for the “Water Supply Scheme for Augmentation of UWSS Lalot, Bandikui, Mandawar and Mandawar, District Dausa including 05 years O&M after 01-year Defect Liability period under ASMRU 2.0.”, following amendments are hereby notified:

S.No.	Events	As per CORRIGENDUM/ADDENDUM NO. 01	Now amended as
1	Availability of bid document.	From 20.02.2026 at 11:00 AM to 06.04.2026 upto 6:00 PM	From 20.02.2026 at 11:00 AM to 21.04.2026 upto 6:00 PM
2	Date & time for online submission of bid document	From 20.02.2026 at 11:00 AM to 06.04.2026 upto 6:00 PM	From 20.02.2026 at 11:00 AM to 21.04.2026 upto 6:00 PM
3	Last date & time for Physical Submission of Bid Security and other mandatory Documents	07.04.2026 up to 02:00 PM	22.04.2026 up to 02:00 PM
4	Date & Time for Opening of Technical bid.	07.04.2026 up to 03:00 PM	22.04.2026 up to 03:00 PM

UBN No. - PHE2526WLOB14606
NIB CODE- PHE2326A5764

(Ajay Singh Rathore)
Additional Chief Engineer
PHIED Region-I, Jaipur

DIPRC/6652/2026

Royals, Royal Challengers face off in a battle royale

Parag’s men are on the rampage with three successive victories to begin the season; the Patidar-led side, loaded with match-winners, is capable of nullifying the threat posed by the host

IPL-19

P.K. Ajith Kumar
GUWAHATI

It should be a battle royale. Neither Rajasthan Royals nor Royal Challengers Bengaluru has tasted defeat yet this season. But one of them will on Friday, when the two in-form sides of IPL 2026 come face to face at the Barsapara Cricket Stadium. RR has played three, won three. RCB has played two, won two.

Good start
It wasn’t in the most ideal situation that the Rajasthan team began its campaign. RR had finished second from bottom last year and then lost its captain and leading batter for over a decade, Sanju Samson, in a trade-off with Chennai Super Kings. Ahead of the season, Sam Curran, one of the players involved in



Left is right: The flamboyant Suryavanshi comes up against a formidable RCB for whom fellow southpaw Padikkal will aim to continue his good form with the bat. RITU RAJ KONWAR

the Samson deal, was ruled out with an injury. But now, just about everything looks perfect for Riyan Parag’s men. In Vaibhav Suryavanshi and Yashasvi Jaiswal, RR boasts the most explosive opening duo in the league this season. While Suryavanshi just aims to send deliveries from every bowler –including the great Jasprit Bumrah – into the stands, Jaiswal paces his innings at will, according to what the

team needs. Then there is the classy Dhruv Jurel to take over from them. In Jofra Archer and Nandre Burger, the franchise has one of the deadliest new-ball attacks, while Ravi Bishnoi has



They have a really good side and some really exciting young players – PADIKKAL

It hasn’t just been reckless hitting. He has picked the balls to hit – BOND ON SURYAVANSHI

Today’s match

 vs. 

Guwahati, 7.30 p.m.

HEAD-TO-HEAD

Played: **33**

RR **14** | RCB **17** | NR **2**

PREVIOUS MEETING

RCB won by **11 runs**, 2025

LIVE ON STAR SPORTS 1 & JIOTHTAR

‘In T20s, 200-plus scores have become the new benchmark’

Sankar Narayanan E.H.

Seldom do IPL teams entrust the opening duties to two young, uncapped batters. All the more reason why Punjab Kings’ punt to go with Prabhsimran Singh (25) and Priyansh Arya (24) – for the second season running – is commendable. Captain Shreyas Iyer and coach Ricky Ponting have taken out the fear of failure from the dynamic duo.



Big influence: Prabhsimran says he shares a special relationship with former India cricketer Yuvraj. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

ers are not just restricted to the PBKS dug-out; they have been training under the watchful eye of Yuvraj Singh. “My relationship with Yuvi paaji is not that of a coach and student. He is like an elder brother to me. Whenever Priyansh and I get time, we tell him that we want to practice. “ Yuvi paaji manages everything himself. We have so much freedom with him that we can even call him at 3-4 in the morning with doubts. We can share anything with him,” he added. Prabhsimran only has good things to say about

his Punjab mate Abhishek Sharma. “It feels nice when your teammate does well. I often pray for his form whether he is going through a good or bad run. My nature is like that... you can call it supportive. I get motivated by seeing him. It’s like a healthy competition where you understand that if your partner has done well, you can also do the same thing.” As Abhishek’s Sunrisers Hyderabad visits New Chandigarh for an IPL showdown on Saturday, maybe it is time for Prabhsimran to claim some brownie points over his opposite number.

PBKS players want to do well for Shreyas, says Connolly

S. Shrivathsan

Punjab Kings may have struck gold with the acquisition of Shreyas Iyer at the IPL mega auction about one and a half years ago. Under the dynamic leadership of Shreyas, the players have been feeling at home, at a franchise that had been in turmoil for many years. Even the newcomers – welcomed to the PBKS family post mini auction – have settled in seamlessly and hit the ground running. One such latest recruit who has been revelling operating under Shreyas is Cooper Connolly. “It is always nice to have a positive attitude like the one we have in our group. It is led by Shreyas, who is always positive. He has this thing; he says: ‘I have a feeling that we are going to win.’ It is not that he is arrogant. It is just that he has confidence in the group and what we can achieve,” Con-



Connolly. FILE PHOTO: R. RAGU

nolly said on JioStar Press Room. “A lot of players follow him, so he leads by example. He is a good person as well, and he is someone who everyone wants to be around. The players want to play under him and do well for him. He deserves that credit,” the Australian said of Shreyas, who ended

a 11-year wait by guiding Kings to the final last year. The presence of head coach Ricky Ponting has also been a blessing for youngsters like Connolly. “A bond has been created over the past couple of years, especially by Ponting. He has been outstanding. He is making sure we are all well connected. We have a common goal, and it is quite obvious that Ponting is helping us get better. He is making sure this team is a close group, and I hope that it allows us to succeed,” added the 22-year-old. Connolly will need Ponting’s pearls of wisdom when the Punjab side braces for the ‘rivalry week’ clash against Mumbai Indians in Mumbai on Thursday – it is to be recalled that Shreyas had punctured MI’s title hopes in IPL 2025 Qualifier 2. With Shreyas and Ponting at the helm, PBKS appears to be in safe hands.

An honour and a privilege, says a proud Shastri

Amol Karhadkar
MUMBAI

Ravi Shastri, the former India captain, urged young Mumbai players to embrace the grind and uphold the city’s rich cricketing legacy after the Ravi Shastri Stand was unveiled at the Wankhede Stadium here on Thursday. “It’s an honour. It’s a privilege to get it on the ground,” Shastri said moments after Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis unveiled the stand on the north side of the stadium. Shastri’s family, including his 86-year-old mother Lakshmi, were in attendance. While listing the illustrious names already associated with the venue, Shastri spoke of the standards expected of Mumbai cricketers. “When you look at the names there (for various stands) – (Sachin) Tendulkar, (Dilip) Vengsarkar, (Sunil) Gavas-



Moment to cherish: Shastri with his family members and Maharashtra CM Fadnavis during the unveiling of the stand while Diana Edulji had a gate named after her at the Wankhede Stadium. EMMANUEL YOGINI

kar, (Rohit) Sharma, and then, of course, the Gates. It’s an association that is rich in tradition. And above all, winners. They win more than anybody else,” Shastri said. Encouraging youth to follow Mumbai’s traditional route, Shastri added: “So to get upstairs there, you have to work your backside off. It won’t come easy. So whoever is young, whoever is aspiring, there is no shortcut. Take those trains, take those buses, do the rounds of the maidans,

play First Class cricket as much as you can, and play whatever cricket is available. That’s the only way you will become a better cricketer. The prime example is Sachin Tendulkar.” Besides the Ravi Shastri Stand, the stadium gates in the names of Diana Edulji, the late Dilip Sardesai and the late Eknath Solkar were unveiled. While Edulji was present, the families of Sardesai and Solkar were in attendance to witness the tribute to the Mumbai cricket stalwarts.

Shastri’s family – including his mother, wife Ritu and daughter Alekha – was present along with his friends. Sunil Gavaskar, his first Test captain, Dilip Vengsarkar, his long-time India and Mumbai teammate, and Suryakumar Yadav also shared the dais with him. “To all the cricketers I played with, thank you very much. Because without you all, this stand would have never come in my name. You were all part of it, right from school to club

Janice and Indonesia too strong for India

BJK CUP

Uthra Ganesan
NEW DELHI



Powering through: Janice hardly put a foot wrong in her match against Sahaja. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

India’s hopes of advancing to the Billie Jean King Cup playoffs suffered a blow as it lost 0-3 to Indonesia in the Asia/Oceania Group I contest here on Thursday. Janice Tjen, the highest-ranked player here, broke no sweat in her 6-2, 6-1 win against Sahaja Yamalapalli in 58 minutes to seal the tie after Vaishnavi Adkar went down fighting to Priska Madelyn Nugroho 6-7(3), 7-6(3), 6-3 in the first match. The World No. 41 cruised home in the opening set, breaking Sahaja in the first game and taking a 3-1 lead. Though the Indian managed to hold serve for the only time in the set, Janice racked up points to win 6-2 in just 31 minutes. In the second, Sahaja was able to win just a solitary game, unable to handle her opponent’s powerful shots. The 23-year-old Indonesian had won her maiden singles title at the Chennai Open last year. Janice returned for the doubles match with the experienced Aldila Sutjiadi as partner. The duo defeated

Ankita Raina and Rutuja Bhosale 6-3, 7-6(4), handing the Indian pair its first reverse of the week. Earlier, Vaishnavi battled hard against Priska. She rallied from 3-5, 15-40 down in the first set and saved three set points. Vaishnavi, who mixed her shots well, broke the Indonesian to pull level 5-5 and took the set to a tie-breaker before winning it 7-3. The second set went Priska’s way, again in the tie-breaker. In the decider, a visibly fatigued Vaishnavi faltered, netting a double-fisted backhand after a three-

hour six-minute marathon. **The results: Indonesia bt India 3-0** [Priska Madelyn Nugroho bt Vaishnavi Adkar 6-7(3), 7-6(3), 6-3; Janice Tjen bt Sahaja Yamalapalli 6-2, 6-1; Aldila Sutjiadi & Janice bt Rutuja Bhosale & Ankita Raina 6-3, 7-6(4)]. **Thailand bt Mongolia 3-0** [Thasaporn Naklo bt Anu-Vjin Gantor 6-1, 6-0; Patcharin Cheapchandej bt Khongorzul Aldarkhishig 6-1, 6-0; Peangtarn Plipuech & Kamonwan Yodpetch bt Jargal Altansarnai & Oyungereel Khasbaatar 6-0, 6-1]. **Korea bt New Zealand 3-0** [Dayeon Back bt Valentina Ivanov 7-5, 6-3; Sohyun Park bt Monique Barry 6-0, 6-1; Dayeon Back & Eunhye Lee bt Aishi Das & Valentina Ivanov 6-3, 3-6, [10-8]].



Cashing in: Sindarov made Pragganandhaa pay for a wrong move. FIDE

Vaishali in sole lead; Sindarov bests Pragg

CANDIDATES CHESS

Sports Bureau

R. Vaishali drew with Anna Muzychuk in the 10th round to move into the sole lead, with six points, in the Women’s Candidates chess tournament at Pegasus, Cyprus, on Thursday. The other overnight leader Zhu Jiner was beaten by Bibisara Assaubayeva. Zhu remains on 5.5. Divya Deshmukh had to pay a heavy price for her unwise pawn-push in a minor-piece ending against Aleksandra Goryachkina, and slid to her second defeat in as many days. With 4.5 points, she is placed second from bottom. Vaishali’s younger brother Pragganandhaa is on the same boat, following his loss to Javokhir Sindarov, who is very close to

winning the title. After the Chennai Grandmaster took his bishop to the wrong square on the 22nd move, fatally as it would turn out, the Uzbek went on to convert his clear advantage into to his sixth win of the tournament. Sindarov has eight points, two more than Anish Giri, who drew with top seed Hikaru Nakamura. Friday is a rest day. **The results (10th round):** Andrey Esipenko (Rus) 3.5 drew with Matthias Bluebaum (Ger) 4.5; Javokhir Sindarov (Uzb) 8 bt R. Pragganandhaa 4; Wei Yi (Chn) 4.5 drew with Fabiano Caruana (USA) 5; Anish Giri (Ned) 6 drew with Hikaru Nakamura (USA) 4.5. **Women:** Anna Muzychuk (Ukr) 5.5 drew with R. Vaishali 6; Divya Deshmukh 4.5 lost to Aleksandra Goryachkina (Rus) 5.5; Bibisara Assaubayeva (Kaz) Zhu Jiner (Chn); Kateryna Lagno (Rus) 5 drew with Tan Zhongyi (Chn) 3.5.

CENTRAL RAILWAY
COMPREHENSIVE AMC SURFACE WHEEL LATHE
Open Tender Notice No: KVV/Prod/CAMC/SWL/26, Dt-08.04.2026.
Name of Work: Proposal for Comprehensive AMC surface wheel lathe (Plant No.196) at Kurduwadi workshop for a period of 5 years on a single-Tender Basis with OEM.
Approx Cost: ₹ 2,30,66,610.50. **Cost of tender form:** Nil. **EMD:** ₹ 4,61,300/-.
Completion Period: 5 years. **The time and date for submission of above e-tenders will be up to 15:00 hrs on 24.04.2026.** Complete details of e-tender is available at official Railway website www.ireps.gov.in **AK-34**
Traveling with dangerous and explosive goods is a punishable offense

SOUTHERN RAILWAY
No.T/C.5/E-Auction/NFR/2026/1
E-Auction leasing tab of website: www.ireps.gov.in
1. E-Auction to award Contract for Display of advertisement on the interior surface of the coaches in Train No. 16865/16866/16866U/20635/20636/56823 (TPJ-TJ-MS-TJ-TPJ EXP & MS-QLN-MS SF EXP) for a period of 3 years.
2. E-Auction to award Contract for Display of advertisement on the interior surface of the coaches in Train No.22627/22628/16341/16342/16807/16808 (TPJ-TVC SF EXP) for a period of 3 years.
3. E-Auction to award Contract for Display of advertisement on the interior surface of the coaches in Train No. 12664/12663 (TPJ-HWH-TPJ SF EXP) for a period of 3 years.
(Auction Catalogue No. TPJ-AD-INT-26-1 dated 06.04.2026)
(Auction commences at 11.00 hrs of 22.04.2026)
4. E-Auction to award Contract for Setting up of Rail Coach Restaurant within the premises of Nagappattinam Railway station for a period of 5 years.
(Auction Catalogue No. MSS-RCR-NGT-261 dated 06.04.2026)
(Auction commences at 11.00 hrs of 22.04.2026)
Full details of E-Auction can be viewed in the E-Auction leasing tab of website www.ireps.gov.in
Sr. Divisional Commercial Manager / Tiruchchirappalli

**GOVERNMENT OF INDIA-DEPARTMENT OF SPACE CONSTRUCTION & MAINTENANCE GROUP, SDSC –SHAR SRIHARIKOTA-524124**

Brief E-TENDER NOTICE
e-Tender Notice No.CMG/C/CON/268701_268702_268703
On behalf of President of India, Item Rate tenders are invited through e-tendering for the following works:

Sl.No	Brief Name of work	Est. Value (Rs)
1	Construction of new RR masonry compound wall at SMN & PNN colonies, Sullurpeta.	612 Lakhs
2	Construction of Test Control Centre at SMP & ETF area, SDSC SHAR (Civil Works).	799 Lakhs
3	Major Civil Refurbishment Works at Space Central School Sriharikota, SDSC SHAR.	321 Lakhs

Last date for sale (Tender documents can be downloaded) up to 01/05/2026 14:30 hrs for Sl.no.1 & 2 and 17/04/2026 14:30 hrs for Sl.no.3. For eligibility criteria and other details, interested tenderers may please refer to the detailed bilingual (Hindi-English) Notice Inviting Tenders (NIT) on the website <https://www.isro.gov.in/Tenders.html> and tender free view at <https://www.tenderwizard.com/isro>
Sd/- GROUP HEAD, CMG/ SDSC SHAR

**CHITTARANJAN LOCOMOTIVE WORKS**
Notice For EOI
No. Med/E/EOI/Radiology, Dated: 31.03.2026. Principal Chief Medical Officer, CLW/Chittaranjan, on behalf of President of India invites (EOI) Expression of Interest for empanement of private (NABH/Non-NABH) HCEs (Health Care Establishment) located within 40 km radius from K.G. Hospital, CLW/Chittaranjan for providing cashless Radiological and other investigations (in Annexure 'A') to the Railway beneficiaries (Serving and retired employees and their dependents) for period of two (02) years on referral against CGHS rates. The details will be available through official website of CLW www.clw.indianrailways.gov.in for "EOI" document. The responses on the prescribed format Annexure-B may be submitted to PCMO/G Office K.G. Hospital/CLW/ Chittaranjan (Room No-5) on or before 29/04/2026 (11:00 hours) during time as mentioned below except holidays i.e **Monday to Friday: 10.30 AM to 16.30 PM, Saturday: 10.30 AM to 12 PM.**
PR/6326 **ACMS/FW/KGH/CLW/CRJ.**
Visit us on: www.facebook.com/clwrailways

**Bangalore Electricity Supply Company Limited**
(A wholly owned Government of Karnataka Undertaking)
(CIN: U04010KA2002SGC030438)
NOTIFICATION INVITING TENDER (NIT)
(Through KPP portal)
No:BESCOM/CGM(Proj)/DGM-1/AGM-1/BC-14/26-27/CYS10
BESCOM Invites tender for the work of “**Replacement of existing LT Overhead lines into LT AB cable in 4 feeders in O&M Unit-1 of Kanakapura Urban Sub-division of Kanakapura Division**” on Total Turnkey basis under Percentage Quoting basis. Tender Enquiry No. : BESCOM/2026-27/EL/ WORK_INDENT1071. Availability of Bid documents : **15.04.2026 onwards.** Last date for submission of bid Queries : **23.04.2026 before 17:00 Hrs.** Pre-Bid meeting : **24.04.2026 @ 11:00 Hrs.** Venue of Pre-Bid meeting : O/o Chief General Manager (Ele), 4th Floor, Project Section, 'B' Block,Corporate Office, BESCOM, K. R Circle, Bengaluru-560 001. Last date & Time for bid submission : **15.05.2026 before 15:00 Hrs.** Opening of Technical Bids : **16.05.2026 @ 15:15 Hrs.** The bid documents can be downloaded and necessary assistance can be obtained through the e-procurement portal from the website: <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in>
E-procurement Help Desk No: +91-8046010000 +91-8068948777 E-mail: support@eprochelpdesk.com
Aspiring bidders needs to be registered on e-procurement portal. Bidders can take the assistance from the e-procurement during office working hours.
Sd/-
Chief General Manager (Ele.)
Projects, BESCOM
E mail: cgmproject.bescom@gmail.com
For Electricity related complaints call: 1912
Download BESCOM Mitra Mobile APP

**EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY**
COPY OF E-TENDER NOTICE FOR DIFFERENT ELECTRICAL WORKS OPEN TENDER FOR ELECTRICAL (TRD)
DRM (Electrical) / TRD / ECR / Dhanbad for and behalf of the President of India invites e-tender for execution of the work indicated as under.
E-Tender No.: TRD-02-OT-TR-GCCIC-26-27
Sl. No. 01. Name of work with location and Completion of work: Dhanbad division-TR (CS+CMSC)- 183 sets. (Completion period (12) (Twelve Months), 02. Approx cost of the work: Rs. 1,04,83,889.53/- (Cost of e-tender form-Nil), 03. Bid Security to be deposited: Rs. 2,09,700/-, 04. Date & Time for submission of closing and opening of E-Tender: Closing of E-Tender- On 29.04.2026 at 11:00 hrs., Opening of E-Tender- On 29.04.2026 at 11:30 hrs., 05. Website particulars: Website: www.ireps.gov.in Manual tender offer not accepted under e-tender.
Divl. Railway Manager (Elect.) / TRD East Central Railway, Dhanbad
PR/0038/DHN/TRD/T/26-27/32

**SOUTH WESTERN RAILWAY**
Corrigendum to Tender Notice No. CAO/CN/BNC/177/2026 Dated : 16-03-2026

Name of the Work	Approx. Value
Conducting Final location survey for New line between Shivamogga Town (SMET) - Sringeri Mangaluru (MAJN) (332 km). Talguppa (TLGP) - Honnavar (HNA) (95 km) Almati (LMT) - Yadgir (YG) (162 km) and Bhadravati (BDVT) - Chikajalur (JRJ) (73 km). (Tender Ref. No. - SWR-FLS-RATE-CONTRACT-03R)	Rs. 33,52,62,609/-

Download the **RailOne** app. RailOne is the all-in-one railway app by Indian Railways. Passengers can book reserved tickets, unreserved tickets, platform tickets, and season passes, check PNR status, order food, and access many more services at their fingertips. Use digital payment to book unreserved tickets through **RailOne** app, and enjoy up to a 3% discount.

For details log on: www.ireps.gov.in
Deputy Chief Engineer / Construction / Works
Bengaluru Cantonment
PUB/20/AAS/PRB/SWR/2026-27
Download the **RailOne** app. RailOne is the all-in-one railway app by Indian Railways. Passengers can book reserved tickets, unreserved tickets, platform tickets, and season passes, check PNR status, order food, and access many more services at their fingertips. Use digital payment to book unreserved tickets through **RailOne** app, and enjoy up to a 3% discount.

PR/0038/DHN/TRD/T/26-27/32

**GOVERNMENT OF KARNATAKA**
Karnataka Maritime Board
Office of the Chief Executive Officer, Karnataka Maritime Board
Khanija Bhavan, No. 49, West Entrance, 3rd Floor, Racecourse Road, Bengaluru - 560001.
Telephone No. 080-29577444 E-mail: ceokmb2019@gmail.com

NOTIFICATION
Sub:Engaging Director Ports and Member (Maritime and IWT operations) on Contractual basis at Karnataka Maritime Board-Reg.
Applications are invited from eligible candidates for engaging Director Ports and Member (Maritime and IWT operations) at Karnataka Maritime Board on contractual basis for an initial period of one (1) year extendable based on annual performance for a maximum period of two (2) years.

Sl. No	Designation	No of Posts	Pay Scale	Qualification									
1	Director Ports and Member (Maritime and IWT operations)	01	Rs. 1,75,000 -2,00,000 (consolidated per month)	1) Must be holder of a Certificate of Competency issued under the Merchant shipping Act, 1958 having validity throughout the Commonwealth as Master in Foreign Going ship; 2) Must have served as Master of a ship 3) Must have experience in Port Administration for not less than ten years in Group-A post equivalent to the port officer of Inland Water Transport under any of the Maritime States in India or the Government of India. 4) Must have the following visual standard with or without glasses namely: <table><thead><tr><th></th><th>Right eye</th><th>Left eye</th></tr></thead><tbody><tr><td>Distant Vision</td><td>V: 6/6</td><td>V: 6/6</td></tr><tr><td>Near Vision</td><td>0.6</td><td>0.6</td></tr></tbody></table> Each eye must have a full field of vision, squint or any morbid condition of the eye or of the eye lids (Trachoma like) of either eye shall be deemed to be a disqualification; and 5) Must not have attained the age of forty-five years.		Right eye	Left eye	Distant Vision	V: 6/6	V: 6/6	Near Vision	0.6	0.6
	Right eye	Left eye											
Distant Vision	V: 6/6	V: 6/6											
Near Vision	0.6	0.6											

Candidates who are eligible for the above post are informed to send their applications to kmb.recruitments@gmail.com **on or before 27.04.2026**, enclosing the scanned copies of Bio data and certificates with passport size colored photograph affixed to the certificate duly attested by the Gazette Officer as per the Proforma given overleaf in the ANNEXURE IN DUPLICATE.

Candidates should bring all the original documents pertaining to their qualification, degree certificates, date of birth, experience and awards if any, etc., produce before the interview committee at the time of Interview. The selection is based on the interview, relevant qualification, experience and roster points as provided by Government of Karnataka (GoK).

No TA and DA will be paid to the candidates appearing for the interview. The appointment is purely on contractual basis for an initial period of one (1) year extendable based on annual performance review for a maximum period of two (2) years and also, appointment under this Notification will not confer any rights on the part of the candidates for any appointment in the Karnataka Maritime Board.

Sd/-, Chief Executive Officer
Karnataka Maritime Board
DIPR/KWR/KSMCA/21/26-27 dt.08.04.2026

MADHYA PRADESH RURAL ROAD DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY
(AN AGENCY OF PANCHAYAT & RURAL DEVELOPMENT DEPARTMENT, GOVT. OF M.P.)
3rd Floor, Vikas Bhawan, Arera Hills, Bhopal (M.P.)
(GST No. 23AAATM9054A3ZX)

DPR CONSULTANCY OF BRIDGES
(Short Time E-Procurement Notice)
No. 3482/22/D-12/Brg.DPR/2026 Bhopal, Dated : 08.04.2026
Online Bids are invited from the reputed Consultants for preparation of DPR of Bridge under PMGSY as per details given below:
• No. of Packages - 22
• Nodal PIU - Khandwa, Khargone, Dhar-1, Barwani, Ujjain, Shajapur, Gwalior, Chhindwara, Jabalpur, Narsinghpur, Pandhurna, Balaghat-1, Mandla, Narmadapuram, Betul, Bhopal, Sehore, Rewa & Satna.
• No. of Bridges - 198
Total Estimated Construction Cost (in Rs.) - Rs. 652800000.00
• Cost of Bid Document, Bid Security (EMD) and service charges as appearing on e-procurement portal are to be paid simultaneously through Debit Card/Credit Card/Internet Banking or system generated challan. For detailed procedure of online payment of EMD and submission of affidavit please refer condition number 2 of detailed NIT.
1. RFP document may be seen, downloaded and purchased from our e-procurement website <https://mptenders.gov.in> from 11:30 hrs. on **17.04.2026**.
2. Last date of Submission of bid is **11.05.2026 up to 13.00 hrs.**
Other details & Conditions may be seen in the detailed NIT and Tender Document for preparation of DPR of Bridges under PMGSY April 2026 amended up to date on our Website <http://mptenders.gov.in>.
CHIEF GENERAL MANAGER (Tender)
M.P. Madhyam/125266/2026
“मेरी सड़क” ऐप डाउनलोड कर, फीडबैक देकर राज्य के विकास में सहयोग दें।

**KARNATAKA HOUSING BOARD**
3rd Floor, Cauvery Bhavan, K.G. Road, Bengaluru - 560009.

Tender Notification
(Through Karnataka Public Procurement Portal only)
Karnataka Housing Board invites online percentage rate composite bids from CPWD/KPWD/Any other State Govt. registered eligible contractors in appropriate class/eligible firms/contractors of reputed on Engineering, Procurement and Construction (EPC MODE-1) turnkey basis under two bids system (Two Cover System) through Karnataka public procurement portal for below mentioned work.
Design, Engineering, Procurement and Construction of International Cricket Stadium and Allied Development Works at Suryanagara 4th Phase KHB Layout, Indlawadi, Anekal Taluk, Bengaluru Urban District, Karnataka (EPC Mode-1).
Work Indent No.: KHB/2026-27/BD/WORK_INDENT 738 & IFT No.04/2026-27
Dated: 07.04.2026. **Amount put to tender:** Rs. 943.46 Crores.

Last date for pre-bid Query	: 22.04.2026 up to 4.00 PM
Pre-bid meeting	: 24.04.2026 at 11.00 AM
Last date for submission of bid	: 08.05.2026 up to 4.00 PM

For further information, contact below mentioned office address: Executive Engineer, Karnataka Housing Board, Cauvery Bhavan, Bengaluru-560009. Telephone No: 080-22273511 and O/o the Executive Engineer, Karnataka Housing Board, Suryanagara 4th Phase, No.52, BSR Layout, Konasandra, Jigani, Bengaluru-560105 Contact No.080-24482702, Website: <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in>
Sd/- Executive Engineer,
Karnataka Housing Board, Bengaluru
DIPR/CP/108/AKAR/2026-27

**बिहार सरकार**

श्रम संसाधन एवं प्रवासी श्रमिक कल्याण विभाग
महत्वपूर्ण सूचना
प्रवासी श्रमिकों के लिए आपातकालीन हेल्पलाइन नंबर
Emergency Helpline Numbers
पश्चिम एशिया एवं खाड़ी क्षेत्र में उत्पन्न वर्तमान परिस्थितियों को ध्यान में रखते हुए बिहार राज्य के नागरिक विशेष कर प्रवासी श्रमिकों की सहायता एवं सुरक्षा के लिए विशेष नियंत्रण कक्ष की स्थापना करते हुए हेल्पलाइन नंबर जारी किए गए हैं। बिहार राज्य के नागरिक / प्रवासी श्रमिक, जिन्हें किसी प्रकार की सहायता की आवश्यकता है, वे निम्नलिखित हेल्पलाइन नंबरों पर संपर्क कर सकते हैं:-
विशेष कंट्रोल रूम
• संपर्क समय : सुबह 8 बजे से संध्या 8 बजे तक
• दूरभाष संख्या : 0612-2520053 एवं
• Whatsapp Mobile No : 7368855002
राज्य के सभी प्रवासी श्रमिकों एवं उनके परिजनों को सूचित किया जाता है कि किसी प्रकार की समस्या, आपात स्थिति में उपरोक्त हेल्पलाइन नंबरों पर संपर्क किया जा सकता है। इसके अतिरिक्त बिहार भवन, नई दिल्ली के मोबाईल नम्बर-9868088065 पर भी संपर्क किया जा सकता है।
सचिव
श्रम संसाधन एवं प्रवासी श्रमिक कल्याण विभाग, बिहार
PR No.- 000640 (LRD)D. 2026-27

**भारतीय सेना/ INDIAN ARMY**
पशु चिकित्सा कोर में अल्प सेवा कमीशन
SHORT SERVICE COMMISSION IN REMOUNT & VETERINARY CORPS

1. भारतीय सेना के पशु चिकित्सा कोर में 95वां अल्प सेवा कमीशन कोर्स हेतु पुरुष और महिला पशु चिकित्सा स्नातकों से आवेदन पत्र आमंत्रित किये जाते हैं।

2. विस्तृत नोटिफिकेशन कृपया वेबसाइट **-www.joinindianarmy.nic.in** पर देखें। आवेदन केवल ऑनलाइन ही स्वीकार किये जाएंगे और आवेदन प्रक्रिया निम्नलिखित अवधि तक होगी:-

2.1. अल्प सेवा कमीशन (आरवीसी) कोर्स (महिला) - **15 अप्रैल 2026 से 15 मई 2026**

2.2. अल्प सेवा कमीशन (आरवीसी) कोर्स (पुरुष) - **17 अप्रैल 2026 से 18 मई 2026**

यदि कोई छूटताछ करनी हो तो, महानिदेशालय पशुचिकित्सा सेवाएं, क्वार्टरमास्टर जनरल शाखा, एकीकृत मुख्यालय रक्षा मंत्रालय (थल सेना), पश्चिमी खण्ड-3, आर के पुरम, नई दिल्ली - 110066 से लिखित अथवा ई मेल आई डी: **persvet-1779@nic.in** में संपर्क किया जा सकता है।

1. Applications are invited from male and female veterinary graduates for 95th Short Service Commission Course in Remount & Veterinary Corps of the INDIAN ARMY.

2. For Detailed notification please visit www.joinindianarmy.nic.in. Applications will only be accepted via online mode and will remain open as under :

2.1. SSC (RVC) Course (Women) - **15 Apr 2026 to 15 May 2026**

2.2. SSC (RVC) Course (Men) - **17 Apr 2026 to 18 May 2026**

Queries if any be sought from Dte Gen RVS, QMG Branch, IHQ of MoD (Army), West Block-3, RK Puram, New Delhi-110 066 in writing OR through E-mail ID : **persvet-1779@nic.in**

नोट :-

1. सेना में भर्ती पूर्णतया पारदर्शी और मुफ्त है। दलालों से सावधान रहें।

2. विस्तृत नोटिफिकेशन और जानकारी के लिए, कृपया www.joinindianarmy.nic.in पर जाएं।

Note :-

1. Recruitment in the Army is totally transparent and free. Beware of touts.

2. For detailed Notification, please visit www.joinindianarmy.nic.in.

CBC 10601/11/0001/2627

Mt. 200 – life comes a full circle for seasoned pro Bhuvneshwar

His experience in guiding and nurturing the next crop of budding pace bowlers is an invaluable asset to any franchise; his ability to keep shifting goalposts and outwitting batters shows his hunger



GETTY IMAGES, VIVEK BENDRE, SPORTZPICS / IPL

R. Kaushik

Where he plying his wares in another era, Ayush Mhatre would have been the talk of the town. Since making his first-class debut a year and a half back, straightaway in the Irani Cup, no less, the little right-hander has tasted success in all three formats. He has two hundreds apiece in first-class, List A (domestic 50-over) and T20 cricket, and made his Indian Premier League debut last year for Chennai Super Kings after coming in as a mid-season injury replacement for his captain, Ruturaj Gaikwad.

In his very first IPL appearance, at his Wankhede Stadium home ground against Mumbai Indians, Mhatre announced himself with 32 off just 15 deliveries as he celebrated becoming CSK's youngest player of all time. A little later in the season, he smacked 94 against Royal Challengers Bengaluru at the M. Chinnaswamy Stadium, almost single-handedly taking his team to a famous victory that wasn't. Two months back, he captained India's Under-19 team to yet another World Cup title, backing up 62 in the semifinal win over Afghanistan with 53 in the 100-run drubbing of England in the title round in Harare.

Mhatre is only 18 years old. A wizened, battle-hardened young lad, sure, but still only 18. He is a star in the making; however, he is smack bang in the middle of the Vaibhav Suryavanshi maelstrom. At 15, Suryavanshi is already a household name, already a superstar. When Mhatre weighed in with 53 against the English boys in Harare on February 6, Suryavanshi smashed 175. And now, in the IPL with Mhatre kicking off the season with scores of 0, 73 and 1, his one-time Under-19 opening partner has again upstaged him with the third fastest fifty (15 balls) in IPL history and with his sensational if brief assault on Jasprit Bumrah that brought him two sixes from the first three deliveries he has ever faced from the genius.

Fear not, Ayush. Your place in IPL folklore is secure.

It may not be the kind of statistic he might want to be remembered by, but surely, there must be something to be said for being an indelible part of history - such as Maninder Singh, whose dismissal brought about the second 'tie' in Test cricket, Wasim Akram, whose fall made Anil Kumble only the second bowler to take all ten wickets in a Test innings, and Shane Warne, who was the last of Harbhajan Singh's three consecutive victims in 2001, when he became the first Indian to take a Test hat-trick.

Alright, so Mhatre might not be in the

same historic league of Maninder, Akram and Warne, but he will forever occupy a place in the record books as the 200th IPL victim of Bhuvneshwar Kumar. At 36, the Uttar Pradesh swing specialist is nearly twice as old as the right-hander from Mumbai, but clearly, he has lost none of his bite, as his recent exploits suggest.

Until last Sunday at the Chinnaswamy, when Bhuvneshwar had Mhatre caught at mid-off by his Royal Challengers Bengaluru captain Rajat Patidar, there was only one occupant of the 200-wicket club in the IPL. Leg-spinner Yuzvendra Chahal, 35 and himself formerly of RCB, must have started to feel lonely, having got to that coveted landmark in 2024. He now has worthy company in Bhuvneshwar, a fabulous servant of Indian cricket who hasn't represented the country for more than three and a half years and is now almost exclusively a 20-over player, but in whom the fire continues to burn bright and undimmed.

It's been 11 months since first Rohit Sharma and then Virat Kohli announced their retirements from Test cricket. Internationally, they only play in the ODI format now and therefore nominally, they must turn out for their respective states in the all-India 50-over Vijay Hazare Trophy to stay in contention for a place in the national side. Much time and energy has been expended over the last year debating the challenges of playing only one format at the highest level, especially given that ODI cricket is the least in-demand of the three variants at the country vs country grade. But Bhuvneshwar has flown under the radar, as he did for the most part of his decade-long India career that brought 294 wickets in 229 games across formats.

Bhuvneshwar hasn't played a representative first-class fixture since January 2024, when he turned up for Uttar Pradesh against Mumbai at the Wankhede. A month and a half previously, he finished with one for 48 against Andhra in Chandigarh in what is most likely to be his final List A appearance. Over the last two years, he has been confined to 20-over cricket alone, both in deference to cricketing years and an overworked body, and while Rohit and Kohli have attracted all the attention even in retirement, Bhuvneshwar has quietly gone about his business without fuss or fanfare simply because he doesn't know any other way.

Master-stroke

Depending on how one wants to view it, it's ironic or coincidental that his milestone moment came with the team that first picked him in 2009, but for whom he didn't play a game until 2025.

Bhuvneshwar was 19 when he joined RCB but didn't figure in the XI for two seasons on the trot until he was snapped up by Pune Warriors ahead of the 2011 season. He was just beginning to find his feet, with 13 wickets while conceding only 6.50 runs per over in his third season with the now defunct team, when Sunrisers Hyderabad swooped in ahead of the 2014 season to secure his services for a modest ₹4.25 crore. What an inspired choice that turned out to be.

In his first season with the boys in Orange, Bhuvneshwar picked up 20 wickets and backed it up with 18 the following year, sparking an extraordinary run of successes as he established himself as his team's most valuable bowling asset, alongside Afghanistan's Rashid Khan. When, under David Warner, Hyderabad secured their first title (Deccan Chargers had emerged triumphant in South Africa in 2009), Bhuvneshwar was the driving force with a Purple Cap-winning 23 strikes. He went three better the next year, with 26 scalps, though Hyderabad's title defence ended in disappointment.

In four seasons, he had accounted for 87 wickets at an economy rate of just over 7, tremendous numbers that amply illustrate the hold he had over the batters. New-ball success was almost a given, because he could swing the white ball both ways and had an especially mean, late inswinger to the right-hand batter. But he also kept adding to his repertoire, working on a variety of slower deliveries and a well-disguised knuckle ball that helped him hold his own at the death when not even his lack of express pace allowed the batters to line him up.

It was impossible for Bhuvneshwar to maintain those extraordinarily high standards. It didn't help that that was when he picked up a series of unrelated injuries which ended his Test career in early 2018. Over the next few seasons, his strike rate dipped and the economy rate surged and it was no surprise that Hyderabad chose to release him into the auction pool ahead of the 2025 season.

The previous year, Bhuvneshwar had taken just 11 wickets in 16 outings while going at 9.35 runs per over, each wicket had taken 5.1 overs in coming. It would have been tempting to overlook his credentials when the franchises gathered in Jeddah in November 2024 for the mega auction; after all, he was closing in on 35 years of age, when fast bowlers in India are put out to pasture, and his immediate record was hardly encouraging.

Value of experience

But RCB saw value in linking him up with Josh Hazlewood, the Australian virtuoso. They had strung together a power-packed batting line-up with a rejuvenated Kohli

helping a group that included Phil Salt, Devdutt Padikkal, Tim David, Jacob Bethell, Jitesh Sharma and Romario Shepherd, under first-time captain Rajat Patidar. They realised the value of experience with the ball, and therefore they went all out to secure Bhuvneshwar's services at the auction. After an intense bidding war that took many by surprise, RCB snared him for ₹10.75 crore. It turned out to be money very well spent.

Hazlewood was the bowling star of the RCB campaign in 2026 with 22 wickets, but Bhuvneshwar wasn't too far behind. In his most successful run since 2017, the man from Meerut snaffled 17 wickets, playing ideal foil to the virtuoso Australian and shaping up as a terrific mentor for the Indian quicks in the franchise, among them Yash Dayal and Rasikh Dhar.

His economy of 9.29 might appear on the higher side until one takes into account the burgeoning rates of scoring and the smallness of several grounds across the country where even totals in the region of 210 are far from adequate. Nine years after playing a starring role in SRH's only title triumph, Bhuvneshwar became a two-time IPL winner when RCB bested Punjab Kings in a close final in Ahmedabad last June.

Bhuvneshwar has started the new season in pretty much the same way as he finished the last one. Two matches have produced four wickets, among them the Mhatre strike that has helped him gatecrash a hitherto exclusive 200-club of one. "Achieving milestones like this is always the result of what you do day in and day out over the years," he acknowledged, with characteristic humility.

"It feels good to get rewarded for the work you've been putting in over the years, so yes, I'm really happy about that. The IPL has been a big part of my career, and reaching 200 wickets is a special milestone. What makes it even more meaningful is that my IPL journey actually started with RCB, so to come back here and achieve this feels like a full-circle moment for me."

Full-circle or not, Bhuvneshwar's career is still in full bloom, almost. Despite the occasional nasty bouncer that catches batters by surprise, he will not terrorise and intimidate through sheer pace. And considering the rapidity with which the white ball has started swinging, his primary weapon has almost been neutralised. Yet, he has managed to keep shifting the goalposts and reinventing himself which, at 36, is huge credit to his hunger, his professionalism and the immense pride that he wears like a badge of honour. Whoever said nice guys don't finish first...

THE GIST

▼ In his first season with the boys in Orange, Bhuvneshwar picked up 20 wickets and backed it up with 18 the following year, sparking an extraordinary run of successes as he established himself as his team's most valuable bowling asset, alongside Rashid Khan

▼ RCB realised the value of experience with the ball, and therefore they went all out to secure Bhuvneshwar's services. The man from Meerut snaffled 17 wickets, playing ideal foil to the virtuoso Australian Hazlewood and shaping up as a terrific mentor for the Indian quicks in the franchise

▼ Reinventing himself at 36, is huge credit to his hunger, his professionalism and the immense pride that he wears like a badge of honour

HEALTH

Semaglutide is off patent: what does this mean for obesity in India?

India is facing a growing epidemic of obesity and metabolic disease and GLP1 drugs are one form of treatment; while a reduction in costs means easier and more widespread access to these drugs, it must be remembered that they serve as add-ons to the fundamental precepts of lifestyle modifications and exercise

Nanditha Ramachandran

When Rakesh (name changed) first walked into the clinic, he could not fit into a chair with armrests due to his body weight. Weighing 169 kg, Rakesh had almost given up on his weight loss goals, having tried multiple diets, and attempted various forms of exercise. “I am fed up, doc!”, he said. “I cannot even drive a car - I cannot fit in the seat!”

Fast forward to today and Rakesh walks in, having lost 37 kgs, over a span of 9 months .

“It has changed my life!” he said.” “I can drive again! I swim now, I feel so much more confident”.

What changed his life was GLP1 therapy, the ‘weight loss’ drugs that have revolutionised the way we treat metabolic disease!

As his doctor, what I see, goes far beyond the numbers on the scale: GLP1 therapy has improved Rakesh’s metabolic health, reduced his cardiovascular risk, improved his fatty liver and optimised his cholesterol and blood pressure. These, therefore, are not just weight-loss drugs: they are disease-modifying agents that target the root of metabolic disease.

GLP1 therapy has taken the world by storm in recent times. These drugs, which have been around for almost two decades now for the management of diabetes, gained popularity, when their indication expanded beyond diabetes, as anti-obesity/weight management drugs.

Obesity has been found to be the main reason for the increasing prevalence of diabetes in all populations. Therefore, targeting obesity seems to be the right strategy, especially at individual levels. GLP1 therapy, in that regard, has been a game-changer, transforming the management of both obesity and diabetes.

The Indian context

The growing burden of type 2 diabetes and metabolic disease, including obesity, in India, is a matter of grave concern. This is related to changing food habits, especially an increase in the consumption of fat, as well as sedentary lifestyles. Indians have a high risk of diabetes and cardiovascular disease, even with lower levels of generalised obesity due to what is known as the “thin-fat” phenotype. This means that even if not obese by overall body weight, Indians have higher body fat percentage and higher insulin resistance, thus increasing our risk for type 2 diabetes and lifestyle diseases.

Targeted therapies such as GLP1, combined with lifestyle changes, can play a crucial role in addressing this growing epidemic in India. GLP1 therapy, when used in the right individual, is a great option for the typical “insulin resistant” Indian. Through its actions, it can result in meaningful weight loss - reducing waist circumference and body fat and improving metabolic health.

On March 22, the originator company,



New-found popularity: From ₹11,000 to ₹18,000 a month for a pen, the cost of GLP1 has now dropped to around ₹5,000 per month, making it more affordable and thus increasing access. GETTY IMAGES

Novo Nordisk’s patent for semaglutide (the active ingredient) expired, and the floodgates opened. More than 50 companies in India have now launched semaglutide at almost half the price that multinational companies sold it at.

What does this mean for India? One of the biggest barriers for GLP1 therapy so far, the cost, may now be overcome. From ₹11,000 to ₹18,000 a month for a pen, the cost has now dropped to around ₹5,000 per month, making it more affordable and thus increasing access.

Who can take it?

GLP1 therapy has clear indications, as to who can use it and when.

Being primarily an antidiabetic agent, its use in type 2 diabetes is clear. In people without diabetes, these drugs have been approved for weight reduction. Here, they can be used in anyone with a BMI of over 27, suffering from obesity-related complications such as obstructive sleep apnea, diabetes, hypertension etc., or in a person with a BMI of over 30 without diabetes. This is a boon to many, in whom lifestyle changes alone do not suffice, and in fact, bridges the gap between lifestyle management and bariatric surgery for obesity management.

It is important to note that these drugs are not shortcuts and not for casual use or as cosmetic quick fixes.

Do they really work, and how?

The short answer is yes. But this also depends on two factors: pharmacogenomics, as each person’s response to a drug may be different, and tolerability to the drug , which in turn determines compliance to taking it, and

ease with dose escalation, as weight loss is best with higher doses.

GLP1 therapy, primarily works through natural pathways in the body, by regulating/suppressing appetite, delaying gastric emptying time and other mechanisms. Hence the response to the drug is largely dependent on each person’s natural response. On an average, a good response would be between 10 to 15% of body weight loss from baseline weight.

As with any other drug, GLP1 therapy must only be used under medical supervision, by a certified health professional.

Side effects are mainly gastro-intestinal (due to the mechanism of action) and include – nausea, loss of appetite, burping and in some cases, diarrhea. However it is important to note, that these side effects are usually transient, and subside after the first few weeks. With medical guidance, these side effects can be mitigated to a large extent.

As far as safety is concerned, there is a rare association with pancreatic inflammation, thyroid tumours and rare case reports of eye complications. Proper guidance and monitoring are key to safe and effective use.

When one stops

If you lost a lot of weight through diet and exercise, and then stopped both, what would happen? You would potentially regain the weight. The same principle applies to GLP1 therapy.As with any intervention, stopping the drugs may cause a regaining of weight to some extent. This serves to illustrate the fact that obesity is a chronic, relapsing condition, requiring long-term treatment.

It is important to reiterate that GLP1 therapy is not a replacement to lifestyle changes or a shortcut for weight loss. It is only an add-on to lifestyle modifications, including diet and exercise.

Another factor to remember while on GLP1 therapy is that it is important to include strength training/muscle strengthening, and sufficient protein in the diet, so as to reduce muscle loss. A study found that the use of semaglutide, when combined with sufficient protein intake and resistance training, resulted in fat mass loss of 18%, and although lean body mass initially dropped, it was subsequently maintained and stabilised.

India is facing a growing epidemic of obesity and metabolic disease, including in the young population.

This looming crisis demands immediate attention and action. GLP1 drugs are one form of treatment and while exciting, there is an urgent necessity to tackle the problem on other fronts. We need to change food policies to reduce consumption of processed food and reduce fat content in marketed food products. Similarly, urban and town planning must be rejigged to encourage physical activity.

Obesity now is considered a chronic metabolic disease. While clinicians today have an effective tool, with GLP1 therapy enriching the landscape of options, the real question that remains is, will this translate into meaningful change in public health? Only time and our actions now, will tell.

(Dr. Nanditha Ramachandran is director and consultant diabetologist at Dr. A. Ramachandran’s Diabetes Hospitals in Chennai. Drnanditharamachandran@gmail.com)

THE GIST

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The growing burden of type 2 diabetes and metabolic disease, including obesity, in India, is a matter of grave concern. GLP1 therapy, in that regard, has been a game-changer, transforming the management of both obesity and diabetes

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GLP1 therapy, when used in the right individual, is a great option for the typical “insulin resistant” Indian. Through its actions, it can result in meaningful weight loss – reducing waist circumference and body fat and improving metabolic health

▼

On March 22, the originator company, Novo Nordisk’s patent for semaglutide (the active ingredient) expired, and the floodgates opened. More than 50 companies in India are now selling semaglutide at cheaper rates than the multinational companies

Climate change reshaping disease patterns, straining health systems: report

Geetha Srimathi
CHENNAI

Climate change is emerging as a major public health threat in India, reshaping disease patterns, straining healthcare systems, and placing nearly 40% of districts at high risk from extreme weather events, according to a new report.

The report, *Under the Weather: India’s Climate-Health Intersections and Pathways to Resilience*, by Dasra, a philanthropy fund organisation, highlights how rising temperatures, erratic rainfall, floods, and cyclones are no longer isolated events but part of a continuous cycle of disruption affecting health, livelihoods, and access to care across the country.

Changing disease landscape

Extreme weather events in India are increasing in frequency and intensity, bringing both immediate and long-term risks, the report notes. Floods trigger outbreaks of water-borne diseases such as cholera and hepatitis, while heatwaves lead to dehydration, heatstroke, and increased cardiovascular stress.

The report says climate change is altering how diseases spread. Warmer temperatures and shifting

rainfall patterns are expanding the range of vector-borne diseases such as dengue and malaria into new regions. Areas that were previously unaffected, including Shimla, parts of Jammu & Kashmir, and the Himalayan foothills, are now reporting cases. The report also identifies Pune as a major dengue hotspot, with cases expected to rise further.

Non-communicable diseases are also linked to climate stress. Heat exposure has been associated with higher cardiovascular mortality, while worsening air pollution contributes to respiratory illnesses and chronic conditions. Climate change, the report says, is acting as a “health-risk multiplier”, increasing both disease burden and pressure on healthcare systems.

Unequal burden

The impact is not evenly distributed. Vulnerable communities – including rural populations, informal workers, women, and children – face the greatest risks. These groups are often the least equipped to cope with climate shocks, deepening existing inequalities.

Extreme heat, for instance, reduces labour productivity and increases health risks for outdoor



Big impact: Vulnerable communities — including rural populations, informal workers, women, and children — face the biggest impact of climate change. K.V.S. GIRI

workers. The report notes that India lost an estimated 160 billion labour hours due to heat exposure in 2021.

Women and children face heightened risks from climate-related health impacts. The report notes that exposure to extreme heat is linked to a 16% increase in the odds of preterm birth

during heatwaves, with risks rising further for every 1 degree Celsius increase in temperature.

Air pollution, particularly fine particulate matter (PM2.5), has been associated with hypertensive disorders in pregnancy, including pre-eclampsia, as well as increased gestational blood pressure. As

infants and young children have limited ability to regulate body temperature, it makes them more prone to heat stress, dehydration, and respiratory illnesses.

Exposure to air pollution is also linked to low birth weight, asthma, and reduced lung function, the report says.

Climate disasters also disrupt access to healthcare. Floods and cyclones can damage hospitals, cut off roads, and interrupt the supply of medicines and vaccines. In remote areas, even a small disruption can leave communities without access to basic services.

Beyond direct health impacts, climate change is also affecting livelihoods and economic stability. Rising healthcare costs, loss of income, and reduced productivity are creating a cycle of vulnerability, particularly for those already at risk.

Efforts taken

Despite these challenges, the report highlights growing efforts to address the climate-health link. Over the past decade, India has begun to move from broad climate policies to more targeted approaches that recognise the connection between climate and health. Initiatives such as the National Action Plan on Climate

Change and Human Health and State-level action plans are helping shape local responses. Heat Action Plans, which include early warnings and preparedness measures, are now being implemented in several cities and districts.

These efforts are helping communities adapt to both immediate shocks and long-term climate risks.

Challenges ahead

However, the report identifies several challenges, including a lack of local, disaggregated data linking climate events to health outcomes, limiting targeted interventions. Funding for adaptation remains constrained and skewed towards mitigation, while weak public awareness and fragmented data systems further hinder effective response.

The report calls for stronger collaboration between government, civil society, and the private sector, along with greater investment in local data systems and climate-resilient healthcare infrastructure. It also calls for placing health at the centre of climate policy, rather than treating it as a secondary concern. (geetha.srimathi@thehindu.co.in)

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Stranded tourists rescued from landslide hit North Sikkim

1,321 Over 1,000 stranded tourists were rescued from Lachen in Sikkim's Mangan district, where multiple landslides have snapped road connectivity, officials said on Thursday. The tourists were stranded in Lachen in North Sikkim since April 5. PTI

Percentage decline in India's goods exports during 2025-26

2-3 in per cent. The country's merchandise exports are expected to register a fall of 2-3% in 2025-26 due to global economic uncertainties, aggravated by the West Asia crisis, according to FIEO. FIEO said that the crisis may have led to a decline in shipments by 7-8% in March. PTI

Number of fraud suspects repatriated by Sri Lanka to China

125 Sri Lankan police have repatriated 125 suspected criminals back to China for their involvement in telecom fraud, the Chinese Ministry of Public Security (MPS) said on Thursday. The suspected criminals had been apprehended during earlier crackdown operations. PTI

Amount approved by Haryana govt. for projects

1,028 in ₹ crore. The Haryana government has granted approval to expenditure of ₹1,028 crore for various projects of more than 10 departments. Approvals were given at a meeting of the High-Powered Purchase Committee. PTI

Number of persons killed in Israeli strikes in Lebanon

203 Lebanon's health ministry said on Thursday that at least 203 people were killed in widespread Israeli strikes in central Beirut and other areas of Lebanon on Wednesday. It said more than 1,000 were wounded. PTI
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What does the Jan Vishwas Bill do?

What does the Jan Vishwas Bill propose? Which offences are being decriminalised? Why remove jail terms for minor lapses? How does the Bill ensure proportionality? How will penalties be structured?

EXPLAINER

G.S. Bajpai

The story so far:

Unnecessary criminalisation is an anathema to business regulations. India's regulatory framework has significant punitive aspects. Under dozens of Central Acts, minor procedural lapses, missed filings, or technical defaults could land a citizen or a small business owner in jail. The Jan Vishwas (Amendment of Provisions) Bill, 2025-26, seeks to shift India's regulatory approach from a punitive model to "trust-based governance." It builds on the earlier Jan Vishwas (Amendment of Provisions) Act, 2023, which decriminalised 183 provisions across 42 Central laws.

Why is the Bill being introduced?

The 2026 Bill proposes amendments to 784 provisions across 79 Central Acts administered by 23 ministries. Of these, 717 provisions are earmarked for decriminalisation, while the rest address ease of living more broadly. Its governing principle is proportionality – the severity of the State's response must bear a rational relationship to the gravity of the conduct it targets.

The Bill pursues three related goals, all rooted in ensuring proportionality in regulation.

First, it seeks a principled separation between conduct that warrants criminal sanction, such as fraud, wilful evasion, and threats to public safety, and procedural non-compliance that carries no comparable moral charge. Conflating the two does a disservice to the seriousness of the former and an injustice to those caught by the latter.

The second objective is equity. Smaller enterprises and MSMEs are disproportionately exposed to compliance risks, not because they violate laws more often, but because they lack the capacity to absorb the consequences when accused of doing so. The idea is to make compliance simpler.



GETTY IMAGES

Third, it seeks to provide institutional relief. India's district and subordinate courts carry over 4.8 crore pending cases (NJDG, December 2025), a significant share of which consists of minor regulatory matters. Decriminalising such cases is not leniency but a rational reallocation of judicial resources.

What are the key features?

The Bill focuses on removing the criminal liability clause for minor procedural lapses and improving the ease of doing business and living.

Its central mechanism is the replacement of criminal penalties with civil and administrative alternatives. The measures on imprisonment provisions are intended to be replaced by monetary penalties calibrated to the gravity of the violation.

For minor or first-time defaults, graded responses such as warnings and advisory notices replace prosecution. Compounding provisions are expanded to provide faster resolution without full adjudication.

Adjudicating officers are empowered to decide cases within defined timelines, with appellate mechanisms to ensure fairness. Penalties are to be periodically revised to retain their deterrent value, and the Bill emphasises digitisation and procedural simplification to reduce inconsistencies in enforcement.

How does it impact institutions?

For the judiciary, the most immediate consequence is meaningful relief. Diverting routine regulatory cases from criminal dockets should free courts to concentrate on matters of genuine public significance.

For regulatory agencies, the Bill increases responsibility. Administrative adjudication is faster and less resource-intensive than criminal prosecution, but it requires institutional capacity, clear guidelines, and oversight mechanisms to avoid arbitrariness. The appellate structures built into the Bill acknowledge this risk, and hence, their effectiveness will depend entirely on how seriously they are operationalised.

For businesses, particularly MSMEs, reduced criminal exposure could meaningfully shift the calculus around formalisation. The fear of prosecution, even where the underlying conduct is technical rather than intentional, has long acted as a disincentive to transparency and engagement with the formal economy.

How does the Bill promote efficient justice?

The indiscriminate use of criminal sanctions – treating a tax fraudster and a businessperson who faltered on a procedural formality – undermines the law's pragmatism. By reserving criminal liability for conduct involving genuine intent or harm, and channelling procedural defaults through civil mechanisms, the Bill narrows the scope for over-criminalisation in a structured way.

A more predictable regulatory environment encourages voluntary compliance. When the consequence of a minor lapse is a proportionate penalty rather than the spectre of prosecution, the incentive structure shifts towards transparency. The durability of these gains will depend on implementation. Enhanced administrative discretion must be matched with clear guidelines, meaningful oversight, and appellate mechanisms that function as genuine checks.

The Jan Vishwas Bill is a serious and overdue reform. Its success will depend less on what it says than on whether the institutions tasked with carrying it forward are genuinely equipped, and held accountable, to do so.

There is a risk of excessive discretion in administrative authorities, weak appellate safeguards in some sectors, the possibility that monetary penalties may replace criminalisation without reducing the burden, and limited clarity on uniform standards across different laws.

(The author is the Vice Chancellor of the National Law University, Delhi. Contributions of Vibhuti Sharma, Academic Fellow, NLU Delhi, are acknowledged)

THE GIST

▼ The Bill seeks to shift India's regulatory framework from a punitive model to 'trust-based governance' by decriminalising minor procedural lapses and ensuring proportionality between the gravity of conduct and the State's response.

▼ It also aims to promote ease of doing business and living, reduce burden on courts through civil and administrative alternatives, while raising concerns about administrative discretion, appellate safeguards, and implementation gaps.

How will Gaganyaan astronauts return safely to earth?

Why can't parachutes alone ensure a safe landing? How does Gaganyaan module lose its enormous speed?

Unnikrishnan Nair S.

The story so far:

The Gaganyaan crew module, which will host the Indian astronauts on their human spaceflight mission, will orbit the earth at about 7,800 m/s. When it re-enters the atmosphere, it will have to shed its kinetic energy. The atmospheric drag itself will be the primary brake, taking away most of its energy in a process called aerobraking. To further reduce the module's velocity for a soft landing, a multi-stage parachute system will be deployed once the module comes within 12 km of the ground. A typical recovery system includes all the items required to soft-land the module in sea or on land after aerobraking. This includes parachutes, locating devices to find out where the module has splashed down, and a system to ensure the module is pointing in a favourable direction in case it drops in the sea. For touchdown on

land, apart from parachutes, the recovery system will fire braking motors to reduce the impact velocity before touchdown. The Russian Soyuz and Chinese Shenzhou modules are designed for terrestrial landing and use retro-rockets for braking.

Why do parachutes alone not suffice?

As the land is hard, touching down on land needs to be around 1-2 m/s. The module can, however, tolerate landing at around 7-9 m/s in the sea, as water is a natural energy absorber.

Land touchdowns also require vast, empty territories free of people or buildings, while offering easier crew recovery and quicker refurbishing of the module.

Sea landings are preferred by countries that lack large deserts or plains. However, it requires recovery ships, flotation bags, and specialised gear to keep the crew safe in rough waters.

Reducing a module's velocity to less than 2 m/s using parachutes alone is

impractical due to the inverse-square relationship between speed and drag area. To slow a module from 7 m/s to 1 m/s, the parachute will have to be roughly 49x larger, incurring a large weight and volume penalty.

A parachute that large would also be difficult to deploy without tangling.

Why is the landing zone elliptical?

When a module returns to the earth, it doesn't aim for a bull's-eye but rather a large ellipse. This is because the module's kinetic energy is concentrated almost entirely along its flight track. At hypersonic speeds, minor fluctuations in atmospheric density or re-entry conditions like velocity can cause the module to over- or undershoot its target by hundreds of kilometres.

In contrast, energy available to make any significant path changes in a direction sideways to its track is very low and hence lateral deviations are minimal. The result is a landing footprint significantly

elongated along the path of travel.

Once a module is in the water, recovery teams use predictive tracking, electronic signalling, and visual aids to find it. The module transmits its GPS coordinates and homing signals to satellites and aircraft and also releases a bright green fluorescent dye.

If the splashdown is at night or in low visibility, flashing from high-intensity strobe lights from the module will be used to locate it. To ensure it stands out against the deep indigo colour of the water, the module and its flotation bags are painted international orange.

How will the Gaganyaan crew module be recovered?

The Gaganyaan recovery operation will be led by the Indian Navy, plus other stakeholders. After the module is slowed by parachutes, it will splash down in the Bay of Bengal. Immediately after, the parachutes will be released to avoid any entanglement and the flotation bags will automatically inflate.

Once naval divers find and secure the module with a flotation collar and towing gear, it will be winched onto a ship's deck to safely extract the crew.

(Unnikrishnan Nair S. is former director, VSSC and IIST; founding director, HSFC; and an expert in launch vehicle systems, orbital re-entry and human spaceflight technologies. Currently Dr Sarabhai Professor at VSSC)

THE GIST

▼ The crew module sheds most of its kinetic energy through aerobraking, with atmospheric drag acting as the primary brake, followed by a multi-stage parachute system and, for land touchdowns, braking motors to ensure a soft landing.

▼ Due to high re-entry speeds and limited lateral control, the landing zone is an elongated ellipse, and recovery involves locating devices, GPS signals, and Indian Navy-led operations after splashdown in the Bay of Bengal.

